READ ME FIRST —
Summary of the Research So Far

Learned Topology in Next-Token Transformers

Do small transformers trained on hidden-walk sequences represent, explain and use the topology of the latent world? (project topo-pilot)

The questions, the methods, every experiment to date (the pilot, the studies of where the learned circle comes from and whether the model uses it, the prediction-horizon studies, the crossing-order studies, the necessity and decoy test of the circle code, the search for a world with more history to measure, the full test there, when that history signal appears during training, whether the predictions use it, and whether the history result holds in three more worlds), the results including the negative and inconclusive ones, and what remains open

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Living document; updated as runs complete.

Compiled from the repository (`topo-pilot`, branch `main`), the coordination mailbox (`agent-handoff`) and the execution stores beside it. Every number is taken from a cited file. The crossing-order study on trained models reached its preregistered decision on 21 October 2026; its decision-stage report is cited where its numbers are used. This text changes no decision. Where it summarises, the cited reviews, reports and frozen protocols are authoritative.

Abstract

I ask whether a small causal transformer, trained from scratch only to predict the next symbol of sequences emitted by a hidden random walk on a world of known topology, develops internal structure that reflects that topology, where such structure comes from, and whether the model uses it. The pilot compares a 12×12 cylinder with a 12×12 square under matched dynamics and emissions, with an exact Bayesian oracle, matched emission controls, and representation baselines, and decides one primary hypothesis by a rule frozen before any model was trained. Under the smooth emission, training produces a persistent-H_1 signal in the final residual stream that separates the cylinder from the square in 24 of 24 panels across three seeds (median contrast 0.158–0.176 against a noise envelope of 0.084–0.097), and its leading H_1 class aligns with the world's periodic coordinate (agreement 0.88–0.89, exact-belief ceiling 0.92). The activation geometry tracks the 32-symbol Bayesian belief more than the last-symbol posterior. A timing hypothesis was rejected, the matched permuted-emission control turned out to be one-sided, the last-symbol embedding alone carries 0.47–0.89 of the contrast, linear probes recover no more belief than the exact next-symbol law does, and a clean-rerun gate failed on one missing historical record. More than a dozen follow-up studies, almost all preregistered, then went after the origin of the circular structure, its causal use, and the necessity of topological distinctions for longer prediction horizons. Most stopped at preregistered feasibility gates (INCONCLUSIVE) or returned scoped negatives; positive results are exact (oracle) facts about designed processes: an orientability distinction needed only two steps ahead, component identity that requires long history, and a process whose predictions depend on the order of loop crossings. In the most direct origin test, the covariance of the learned chart phase with the part of the belief that the last four observations do not determine was excluded from beyond a ± 0.01 margin in all three models; the registered margin, however, lies above what the oracle's own phase achieves. A crossing-order study trains twelve models on a non-abelian (S_3) transport process to test whether trained transformers use the order of seam crossings beyond every commutative summary; all validity gates passed and the preregistered outcome is INCONCLUSIVE. In every seed the trained models carry a small but clearly non-zero order-dependent component on natural histories (mean $\tilde{\beta} = 0.061$, lower bound 0.0595; commutative controls and initialisations near zero), an order of magnitude below the registered effect size of 0.25, and they do not beat the bar on the designed witness histories; one commutative control's response to a designed placebo prevents the registered "order not detected" verdict. The latest study gives the first causal-use result for a trained model. After the final LayerNorm the readout is exactly linear, so the model's own response to natural counterfactual histories (the x-history rotated by two cells, the last symbol kept) can be attributed exactly to its circle code. Interchanging the six coordinates of the registered, nuisance-excluding circle code carries 85% of the model's signed oracle-aligned response ($\hat{\psi} = 0.851$–0.856, lower bounds far above the preregistered 0.50) in all three pilot models: the readout uses this code (USED). The same holds for the layer-2 code transmitted through the remaining computation and for a code built from the oracle's phase. The claim is scoped to the registered linear code; it does not exclude other encodings of the same information. A follow-up on fresh histories shows that the code is the main carrier but not the only one (everything outside it carries 14–15% of the response, in all three models), and that the method can say "not used": on decoy models whose readout ignores the code exactly, while the code stays in the activations, it returned NOT_USED in all three. A check with no training found that one commutative control's response to the designed crossing-order placebo replicates on fresh histories but matches neither order use nor a simple miscount, so its cause remains unexplained. An oracle-only sweep of 225 worlds found one, the same cylinder with wider emissions, in which the oracle's own beyond-four-symbol signal is 4.7 times the registered margin. After a two-model training pilot there passed every registered gate, a full test trained three new models in that world and asked the origin question again under the same decision rule. The registered outcome is SUPPORT in all three models: the covariance of the learned chart phase with the beyond-four-symbol part of the belief has lower bounds 0.039–0.041, four times the 0.01 margin, and reaches 89–93% of the oracle comparator on the same test rows. On its supported rows the learned coordinate is therefore not a function of the last four observations; it depends on earlier history, in the direction of the oracle's belief. The claim covers these three models in this world; the earlier exclusion in the pilot world stands. Two follow-ups on the same three models are complete. Read at twelve saved checkpoints of each training run, the beyond-four-symbol covariance was already above the margin when the

first validated chart appeared (in two models a chart that had not yet passed validation carried it even earlier), and before the predictions first beat every predictor that sees only the last four symbols; no model showed a certified loss later. A test of use then asked whether the models' next-symbol predictions depend on that history. On pairs of natural histories that share their last four symbols, the predictions move in the direction of the oracle's change by 0.88–0.93 of the oracle's own discrimination, and the registered outcome is RESPONDS in all three models; a predictor that reads only the last four symbols would show zero. How much of this response runs through the circle code was not assessed: an oracle-only stage found that this share could not be measured with the registered precision, so it was dropped before any model was measured. A worlds study then repeated the full test, unchanged, in three more worlds chosen in advance by an oracle-only rule to span a 6.4-fold range of beyond-four-symbol signal, with three newly trained models per world. In the two worlds that reached the endpoint the outcome is SUPPORT in all three models (lower bounds 0.031–0.033 and 0.072–0.079 against the margin 0.01), and each of the six models captures at least half of the oracle comparator (about 95% and 91% on average). In the third and noisiest world all three models learned, but for one of them the registered chart rule did not produce a valid chart, so that world is inconclusive and no claim across all worlds is made.

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1 Introduction

Large language models are trained to predict the next token, yet they are often described as carrying "world models". Whether, and in what sense, next-token training produces representations that mirror the latent structure of the process generating the data is an empirical question that is hard to answer on natural text, because the latent structure is unknown. Synthetic processes whose latent state, dynamics and exact Bayesian predictor are fully known make the question tractable. Prior work established that transformers trained on hidden Markov models (HMMs) linearly represent the geometry of the Bayesian belief state in their residual stream [67, 75], and that sequence models trained on games or walks can carry recoverable world state [14, 48, 80]. Topology—global invariants such as the number of independent loops—had not been controlled in this setting.

The **topo-pilot** project trains a small causal transformer from scratch on symbols emitted by a lazy random walk on one of two worlds with the same number of states and the same local rule: a *cylinder* (one independent loop, $\beta_1 = 1$) and a *square* ($\beta_1 = 0$). It asks three nested questions, fixed in the binding specification `docs/RESEARCH_SUMMARY.md` §1 and later in the owner's research charter (`agent-handoff/NEXT_RESEARCH_AND_WORKFLOW_EN.md`):

RQ1 Existence. Does the context-dependent representation acquire structure that reflects the latent topology?

RQ2 Origin. If so, does that structure come from the geometry of the observations, from beliefs accumulated over the history, or only from what is needed to predict the next token? (Charter priority 1: how much of the circular structure is explained by the last symbol or a short context, and how much requires long history?)

RQ3 Use. Does the model use the structure for prediction, or is it merely detectable? (Charter priority 2.) A third charter priority asks whether some topological distinctions are unnecessary for the next symbol but necessary for a longer future.

Two secondary programmes extend the question: does the world's geometry change learning speed, and can a model use topology richer than H_1, namely non-abelian transport, where the *order* in which loops are traversed matters? Table 2 in §3 lists every study by a descriptive name; the short internal labels of the project records (for example K4b or X6S1) appear only there and in the appendix tables, as keys for readers who want to look up a record in the repository.

The project is also an experiment in research process. I froze every decision rule before the data it decides existed. Each protocol was planned twice independently and reviewed result-blind before freezing, and the critical tests were written by authors who never saw the implementation. Compute is metered, fresh test histories are protected by exposure registries, and failures are classified as technical (correctable at most twice), inconclusive, or scientific. I did much of the work with language-model agents: OpenAI Codex and Anthropic Claude models served as independent planners, result-blind reviewers, implementers and test authors, and a Claude session acted as coordinator (issuing rulings and writing reviews under my authority) with workers launched per job, all communicating through a version-controlled mailbox. I approved every scientific decision point.

Summary of findings. Table 1 lists the main outcomes; Figure 1 places all of them in time.

1. **RQ1, positive under the smooth emission O.** The preregistered F1 rule is supported in every panel and replicate; the detected loop is the world's periodic circle (§5).
2. **RQ2, partially answered.** The geometry follows the full-history belief, also among histories with the same last symbol, and the learned circle exceeds an optimistic last-symbol bound. But the last-symbol embedding already carries much of the contrast, the timing

hypothesis was rejected, beliefs converge quickly with history length, and the most direct test found the beyond-four-symbol covariance of the learned phase to be smaller than 0.01—a margin that the oracle's own phase also does not reach (§6). In a world with more such information, a full test found it in all three new models (§6.7).

3. **RQ3, answered for the registered code.** The first two intervention designs, erasing the circular coordinate and forcing a counterfactual state, stopped at preregistered feasibility gates before any causal endpoint was scored. The third design attributes the model's own response to natural counterfactual histories exactly to its circle code at the final readout: the code carries 85% of the oracle-aligned response in all three models, and the preregistered outcome is USED (§7). A follow-up on fresh histories confirmed that the code is the main carrier but not the only one, and showed on decoy models that the method returns "not used" when the code is present but unread (§7.4).

4. **Horizons and richer topology.** Exact oracle computations prove the existence of an orientability distinction that is invisible one step ahead and needed two steps ahead, but the trained-model study of it failed its learnability gate. An S_3 transport process was certified to carry order information beyond every commutative statistic; the trained follow-up reached its preregistered decision, INCONCLUSIVE: a weak but reproducible natural order sensitivity, far below the registered size (§8, §10, §10.2.1). A follow-up check left the cause of one control's response to the designed placebo unexplained (§10.3).

5. **A world with more history to measure.** An oracle-only sweep of 225 worlds selected one in which the oracle's beyond-four-symbol signal is 4.7 times the registered margin, so that the origin question can be asked again with room to answer it (§6.6). After a two-model training pilot passed, a full test with three new models returned SUPPORT in all three: the learned phase carries information from beyond the last four symbols (§6.7). Over training, that information was present no later than the first validated chart and before the predictions beat every last-four-symbol predictor (§6.8). The models' predictions respond to it, in the direction of the oracle's belief, in all three models (RESPONDS); how much of that response runs through the circle code was not assessed (§7.5). Repeated unchanged in three more worlds, the full test returned SUPPORT in all three new models of two worlds; the third world is inconclusive because one model's chart failed validation, so there is no claim for all worlds (§6.9).

2 Background and related work

2.1 Transformers, hidden Markov models and belief states

An HMM with transition matrix T and emission matrix E induces, for every observed history, a posterior over latent states: the belief state, obtained by Bayesian filtering [69]. The set of reachable beliefs, together with the map from belief to future-symbol distributions, is the object studied by computational mechanics, where the minimal sufficient statistic of the past for the future (the causal state, or ε-machine state) is the natural notion of what an optimal predictor must remember [18, 76]. Predictive-state and observable-operator representations express the same information through future-observation statistics [42, 78]. Shai et al. showed that transformers trained on small edge-emitting HMMs linearly encode the belief-state simplex, including fractal belief geometries, in the residual stream, sometimes only in the concatenation of layers [75]; Piotrowski et al. explained the layer-wise geometry as constrained belief updates by attention followed by nonlinear correction [67]. Related accounts treat in-context learning as implicit Bayesian inference over latent concepts [82], show how transformers learn Markov-chain statistics in context through induction-like heads with stage-wise dynamics [9, 21, 60], and study what function classes can be learned in context

Table 1: Headline outcomes. "Label" is the outcome vocabulary of the governing frozen protocol. Sources: `README.md`; `reports/E2--E4`; `state/DECISIONS.md`; `agent-handoff/jobs/<job>/review.md`.

Study	Label	One-line reading
Pilot: a hole in the cylinder only (rule F1, smooth emission O)	SUPPORTED	$D > 0$ in 24/24 panels; median above envelope in 3/3 seeds
Pilot: geometry follows the full-history belief (H2)	sign-consistent	geometry tracks $b^{(32)}$ over $b^{(1)}$ in 48/48 panels
Pilot: the F1 rule under the permuted control P (H3)	REJECTED, uninformative	even the exact belief fails under P
Pilot: belief alignment under P (H3′)	SUPPORTED	ρ_s 0.06–0.11 $\rightarrow$ 0.70, beats mixing baselines
Pilot: the hole appears after history use (H4)	REJECTED	S rises at step 50, history use at step 100
Pilot: clean rerun from an empty store	FAIL	307/307 shared artifacts bitwise; one historical record missing
Two-step-ahead distinctions in the pilot world	INCONCLUSIVE / scoped NO-GO	no witnesses at the registered resolution
Erasing the circular coordinate (causal)	INCONCLUSIVE	linear eraser leaves nonlinear information; no matched controls
Geometry and learning speed	REJECTED	paired delays 250/0/0 steps (kernel confounded with speed)
Origin beyond the last 8, then 4, symbols (first attempts)	headroom FAIL / INCONCLUSIVE	no room at $K = 8$; chart gate failed at $K = 4$
Orientability needed only two steps ahead (oracle)	PASS	invisible one step ahead, needed two steps ahead
Component identity beyond short windows (oracle)	GO	component identity needs long, non-additive history
Orientability in trained models	NOT_LEARNED	both gate models failed the learnability criterion
Counterfactual state forcing (causal)	INCONCLUSIVE	intervention moved protected readouts; no matched controls
Origin beyond the last four symbols	EXCLUSION	$\lvert\Delta_4\rvert < 0.01$ in 3/3 models; oracle comparator 0.0085
Crossing order in the oracle	GO	order effect certified beyond every commutative statistic
Crossing order in trained models	INCONCLUSIVE	all validity gates PASS; mean $\tilde{\beta} = 0.061$, below the registered 0.25
Readout attribution of the circle code (causal)	USED (3/3 models)	the registered code carries $\hat{\psi} = 0.85$ of the aligned response; layer-2 and oracle-phase codes also USED
World sweep for history signal (oracle)	SELECTED	a wider-emission cylinder: beyond-four signal 0.047, 4.7× the margin
Training pilot in the selected world	PASS (uncertified)	both models learn and form the circle; a full test is powered
Full test in the selected world (beyond 4 symbols)	SUPPORT (3/3 models)	L 0.039–0.041 against the margin 0.01
Control's response to the designed order placebo	UNEXPLAINED	the response replicates; it matches neither order use nor a symmetric miscount
Necessity of the circle code; decoy test	CODE_ DOMINANT; DECOY_NOT_ USED (3/3 models)	the complement carries 14–15%; the method returns NOT_USED on decoys
When the beyond-four signal appears in training (new world)	report (six registered statements)	present by the first validated chart, before the predictions beat every last-four predictor
Do predictions use history beyond four symbols (new world)	RESPONDS (3/3 models); share not assessed	response 0.88–0.93 of the oracle's own discrimination
Full test repeated in three more worlds	SUPPORT, SUPPORT (3/3 models each); third world INCONCLUSIVE	every model captures at least half of the oracle comparator; no all-worlds claim

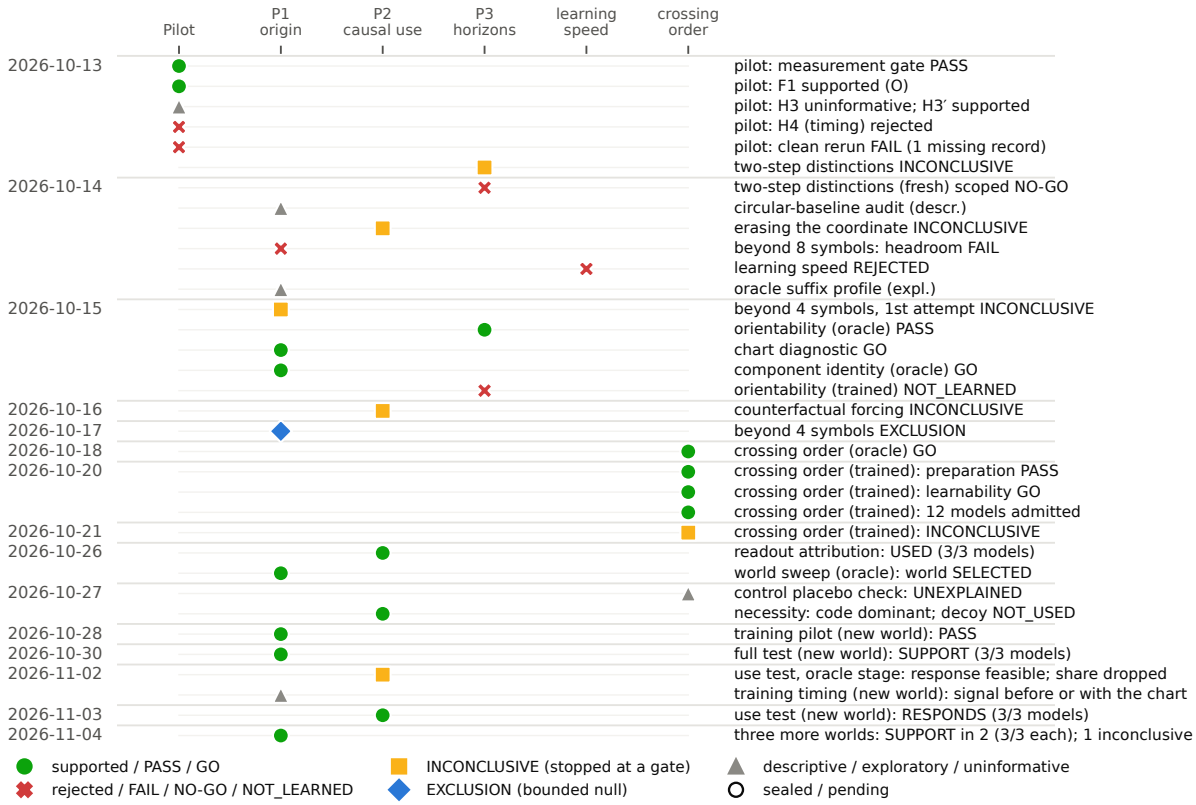


Figure 1: Programme timeline. Each row is one recorded stage outcome, placed in the column of the research question it served (P1–P3 are the owner charter's priorities). Order within a day follows the decision log; spacing is not to scale. Sources (one per row, in `make_figures.py`): `state/DECISIONS.md` D-017, D-049, D-052, D-054, D-057, D-063, D-073, D-074; `reports/E2/summary.md`, `reports/E3/summary.md`; `x4-history-feas-store/GATE_REPORT.json`; `agent-handoff/jobs/<job>/review.md` for jobs 0018, 0020, 0023, 0025, 0033, 0044, 0057, 0066, 0089, 0092, 0093, 0094, 0099, 0115, 0136, 0155, 0167, 0175, 0196, 0206, 0222, 0237 and 0264.

[30]. More recent preprints report factored representations when latent factors are independent [74] and belief geometry in pretrained models in context [3].

Relation to this project. The pilot uses exactly this oracle machinery (§4.1): the exact filter supplies the 32-symbol belief $b^{(32)}$, the last-symbol posterior $b^{(1)}$ and the future laws F_1, F_2, and every learned geometry is compared with these model-free spaces on the same histories. Two design choices come directly from this literature. First, the axis-wise emission permutation P (§4.1) preserves the exact product structure of the smooth emission, because factor-wise representations are expected [74]. Second, layer-wise and concatenated hooks are analysed because belief geometry need not sit in one layer [67, 75]. The pilot's addition is a controlled *topological* contrast at matched state count, and persistent homology on clouds of individual histories rather than on per-state centroids.

2.2 World models, emergent geometry and in-context representations

Othello-playing sequence models carry recoverable board state [48]; models trained on random walks can predict well without a coherent world model by stricter metrics [80]; pretrained language models represent space and time linearly [33] and some features are irreducibly multi-dimensional, including circular ones such as days of the week [26]. Pretrained models reorganise their representations to match a graph defined in context, but the analysis there uses per-node averages, whose principal components reproduce the spectral embedding of the graph [65]. Closest

to the pilot in spirit, Jerpelea planted a ring-structured latent Markov variable in generated text and found ring geometry in a from-scratch student, using centroids and PCA [43]; Brenner et al. studied fully observed lattice walkers, whose residual stream encodes running averages of steps [14].

Relation. These results make two pitfalls concrete. Per-state averages import the world's structure from outside the model, and short-range symbol mixing alone can create global lattice structure. The pilot therefore forbids centroids, UMAP/t-SNE and k-NN geodesics as evidence, and adds two model-free mixing baselines (previous-token mixing of a spectral symbol embedding, and the context average), together with the trained last-symbol embedding (`docs/RESEARCH_SUMMARY.md` §7.2, §7.6). The claim of the pilot is accordingly narrow: the general phenomenon "periodic latent dynamics can shape periodic geometry" has prior art [43]; the pilot contributes a matched two-topology comparison with these controls. I do not claim priority.

2.3 Formal languages, automata, groups and state tracking

Theoretical work bounds what fixed-depth self-attention can compute: hard and soft attention cannot robustly recognise parity or Dyck languages at arbitrary length [34], empirical studies map the formal languages transformers learn [8], and a Chomsky-hierarchy benchmark finds transformers weak at state tracking beyond regular languages without structural help [20]. Log-precision transformers lie in uniform TC^0 [55]; since the word problem of S_5 is NC^1-complete by Barrington's theorem [4], neither transformers nor common state-space models can track general non-solvable group state at arbitrary length unless $\mathrm{TC}^0 = \mathrm{NC}^1$ [56, 73]; negative eigenvalues restore some state tracking in linear RNNs [32]. For *solvable* groups, transformers learn shallow "shortcuts" whose existence follows from the Krohn–Rhodes decomposition [46, 49]. Empirical mechanistic work shows that networks learn group operations through representation-theoretic circuits [16], that language models track permutation state with associative and parity-associative mechanisms [47], and a recent preprint argues that standard transformers learn cosets of normal subgroups [85].

Relation. The crossing-order studies rest on this distinction. Their transport group S_3 is non-abelian but solvable, so the composition task is expressible at fixed depth [49], so expressivity is not in doubt; the question is whether next-token training on a *topologically generated, implicitly observed* group word yields order-sensitive predictions beyond commutative summaries. The commutative competitors form a ladder (parity, which is the quotient S_3/A_3; signed crossing counts, i.e. the H_1 class; unsigned counts; the full Parikh vector of directed crossings, the strongest commutative statistic of a word [64]). The coset account predicts either full order use or parity-level behaviour for S_3, whose normal subgroups are trivial, A_3 and S_3 [85]; the trained crossing-order protocol records this as a named competing hypothesis, checked against the preprint's abstract only.

2.4 Order sensitivity versus bag-of-words

Transformer language models use much less word-order information than their architecture permits: ablating order within long-range context changes little [62], and pretraining on shuffled text retains much downstream performance [79]. *Relation.* The crossing-order studies make the order question exact: on designed history families with identical token and directed-bigram multisets, the oracle's next-symbol law still differs, so any bag-of-tokens predictor has a certified excess loss (§10.1). On the natural distribution, however, bag mechanisms are *not* excluded by the trained study's design, and the protocol says so.

2.5 Mechanistic interpretability, probing and interventions

Circuit-level analysis of transformers [24], induction heads [63] and superposition [25] supply the vocabulary of residual stream, heads and readouts used here. Linear probes [1] measure decodability, not use; control tasks and selectivity are needed to interpret them [6, 39]. Linear concept erasure [7, 70] removes linearly decodable information but may leave nonlinearly decodable information; causal claims require interventions such as interchange interventions, causal abstraction or activation patching [31, 37, 54, 84].

Relation. The pilot's probes compare decoding of $b^{(32)}$ from activations against decoding from the exact next-symbol law and from a one-hot last symbol, which acts as a competitor-matched control in the spirit of Hewitt and Liang [39]. Both of the project's causal designs met the known failure modes of interventions: the targeted linear eraser removed linear recoverability while a nonlinear (RBF) decoder still recovered the coordinate at 0.998, and no random eraser matched its damage; the state-forcing direction shifted protected readouts that matched controls left nearly untouched (§7). The third design uses interchange of natural histories at a site where the readout is exactly linear.

2.6 Grokking and learning dynamics

Small transformers on algorithmic tasks can generalise long after fitting the training data [68]; mechanistic progress measures reveal a gradual circuit formation behind apparently sudden transitions [59], and different runs can implement different algorithms for the same modular task [86]. *Relation.* H4 asks a timing question of this kind (does topology appear only after history use begins?), and the trained crossing-order study trains for 30,000 updates because the orientability study's 10,000-update recipe showed a flat dev loss from step 1,000; I chose the longer run; it is not a tuned value.

2.7 Topological data analysis of representations

Persistent homology tracks homology classes across a filtration [15, 22, 88]; diagrams are stable under perturbation [17], admit confidence sets [27], and circular coordinates can be extracted from persistent cohomology classes [19]. Vietoris–Rips barcodes are computed efficiently by Ripser [5]; universality of random persistence diagrams is conjectured or proved under specific conditions [10]. Persistent homology has revealed toroidal structure in grid-cell populations [29], tracked topology through deep networks [58, 71], and been applied to language-model activations, where matched Gaussian clouds produce hundreds of spurious H_1 bars and pseudoreplication must be avoided [52]; another study argues that transformer token clouds within a sentence are topologically simple [28]. Sheaves and local systems formalise local-to-global consistency [35] and have entered neural architectures [11]; local systems and holonomy are classical [36].

Relation. The pilot computes Vietoris–Rips homology over $\mathbb{F}_2$ on clouds of 512 individual histories, normalises the longest finite H_1 bar by a cloud scale, and reports a Gaussian floor as context, never as a threshold. Following Hurlbert [41] and Malhotra et al. [52], panels within a run are not treated as replicates; the decision uses sign consistency across three seeds and eight disjoint panels. The ground truth is computed from an explicit cubical complex, because the transition graph of the square has 121 independent cycles that are filled faces, not holes. The crossing-order process uses a local system (a flat S_3 connection with one non-flat face) in the *generator*; nothing is claimed about the trained model being a sheaf.

2.8 Concentration bounds and resampling

The bootstrap [23] is used throughout for descriptive intervals and several confirmatory rules, with stated nominal (not distribution-free) coverage. Where a finite-sample guarantee is needed, the trained crossing-order study uses an empirical-Bernstein bound for a bounded loss: variance-adaptive bounds of this type are due to Audibert et al. [2] and Maurer and Pontil [53], in contrast to the variance-blind Hoeffding inequality [40]; see Boucheron et al. [12] for background. The protocol derives its own version with a paired U-statistic for the variance, at a small cost in constants relative to Maurer and Pontil [53] (§10.2).

2.9 Preregistration, reproducibility and leakage

Undisclosed analytic flexibility inflates false positives [77]; preregistration separates confirmatory from exploratory analysis [57, 61]. In machine learning, variance across seeds and tooling undermines single-run claims [13, 38, 87], and reproducibility programmes have been proposed [66]. Data leakage and test contamination are a recurrent source of invalid results [44, 45, 51, 72]. *Relation.* The methods of §4 are meant as a strict response to these problems: frozen rules, result-blind review, three-valued outcomes, exposure registries for fresh test histories, sealed validation quantities, and bitwise rerun checks.

3 The research programme

The programme grew in three phases.

Phase 1: the pilot (12–13 October 2026). A staged plan (`docs/STAGES.md`) first validated the measurement pipeline on ground truth, then established that the exact oracle spaces separate the two worlds, then trained the models and decided the two main hypotheses, then ran the permuted-emission control and the timing analysis, and finally added controls, probes, circular coordinates, sensitivity analyses and a clean rerun. The plan names these five exit points E0–E4, and §5 follows them in order. Four checkpoints required my approval. Seventeen models were trained on CPU.

Phase 2: follow-ups on origin, use and horizons (13–17 October). After the pilot I fixed the charter priorities quoted in §1. Each follow-up was a separate, frozen protocol, listed in Table 2.

Phase 3: non-abelian topology (17 October–). An exact computation certified that an S_3 transport process carries order information beyond every commutative statistic; a trained study (frozen 18 October, authorised 20 October) then trained twelve models on it, on a free cloud GPU, with all evaluation local. From 21 October a third causal-use design was planned, frozen and implemented; it reached its decision on 26 October. On 26 October I adopted a next-round plan with sharper working rules (oracle feasibility first, a synthetic dry run before every freeze, every control checked on a known case). Under it, three studies without training ran in parallel on 26–27 October within a 12 CPU-hour line: an oracle sweep of worlds for the history-origin question, a check of the crossing-order control's placebo response, and a necessity and decoy test of the circle code. A small training pilot in the world the sweep selected passed on 28 October; I approved the full test on 29 October, and it reached its decision on 30 October. On 1 November I adopted two follow-ups on its three models: when the beyond-four signal appears during training (run on 2 November) and whether the predictions use it (an oracle-only stage on 2 November, the model stage on 3 November). The worlds study was planned and approved on 3 November and ran on 3–4 November.

How the questions connect. The pilot answered RQ1 positively under O and left RQ2 split between "observation geometry" and "history", because the last-symbol embedding alone

Table 2: Guide to the studies. Each study is named in this document by the descriptive name in the first column. The internal label is the key used in the project records and in Appendix B; readers do not need it.

Study	Internal label	Question	Section
The pilot	E0–E4	Does training on the cylinder, and not the square, produce a learned loop?	5
Circular-baseline audit	—	Does the learned circle exceed what the last symbol permits?	6
Oracle suffix profile	—	How fast does the circular posterior converge with suffix length?	6
Origin beyond the last 8 symbols	K8	Is there room to test history beyond 8 symbols?	6
Origin beyond the last 4 symbols, first attempt	K4	Does the learned phase covary with history beyond 4 symbols?	6
Origin beyond the last 4 symbols	K4b	The same question with a repaired chart rule	6
Component identity beyond short windows (oracle)	X2a stage 0	Is long, non-additive history ever required?	6
Erasing the circular coordinate	X4-F	Does prediction depend on the circular coordinate?	7
Counterfactual state forcing	C1, C1′	Does the readout respond to a forced change of the phase?	7
Readout attribution of the circle code	C2	How much of the model's response to history runs through its circle code?	7
Necessity of the circle code and decoy test	C2ND	Is the code the only carrier, and can the method say "not used"?	7.4
World sweep for history signal (oracle)	HWS stage A	Is there a world with more beyond-four history signal to measure?	6.6
Training pilot in the selected world	HWS stage B	Do models trained there learn and form the circle, and would a full test be large enough?	6.7
Full test in the selected world	HWS stage C	Does the learned phase of three new models covary with history beyond four symbols?	6.7
Timing of the beyond-four signal in training	HWS track D	When, during training, does the learned phase start to carry it?	6.8
Use of history beyond four symbols	HWS track U	Do the new models' predictions depend on it, and how much through the circle code?	7.5
The full test in three more worlds	HWSG	Does the beyond-four result hold in other worlds, and do models capture a similar fraction of the oracle's signal?	6.9
Two-step-ahead distinctions in the pilot world	X4 Phase B, B2	Do beliefs exist that agree one step ahead but not two?	8
Orientability needed only two steps ahead (oracle)	D-1	Can a topological distinction be invisible one step ahead?	8
Orientability in trained models	D-2a	Do trained models carry that distinction?	8
Geometry and learning speed	X5 G1	Does a curved kernel slow learning?	9
Crossing order in the oracle	X6 stage 0	Does a designed process carry order information?	10.1
Crossing order in trained models	X6 stage 1 (X6S1)	Do trained models use crossing order?	10.2
Control's response to the designed placebo	X6ZC	Why does a commutative control respond to the designed order contrast?	10.3

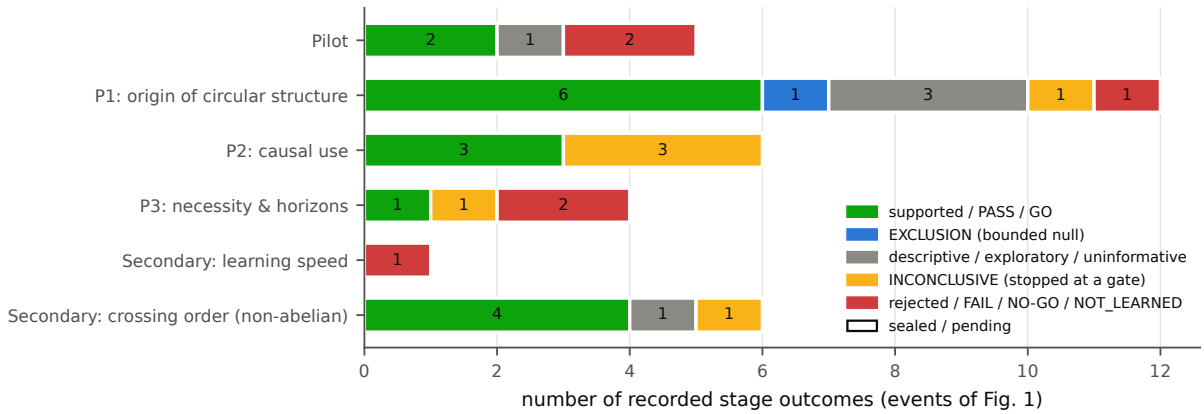


Figure 2: Outcome summary by research question: the number of recorded stage outcomes of Figure 1 in each outcome class. Supported outcomes are concentrated in the pilot and in oracle-only studies; trained follow-ups mostly stopped at gates. Source: the event list in `make_figures.py` (`EVENTS`), each with its cited review or decision record.

already reproduces much of the contrast. The origin studies sharpened RQ2 into a quantitative question about suffix lengths, which the oracle suffix profile showed can only be asked for short suffixes, because the circular posterior converges quickly. The causal studies went at RQ3 directly and stopped at feasibility gates; they showed that the circular information is encoded nonlinearly and that naive interventions are not specific. The horizon studies moved from a scoped negative on the pilot world to a constructed world where a topological distinction is provably needed only two steps ahead; the trained version did not learn it. The component-identity and crossing-order oracle studies looked for processes where long and order-dependent history is genuinely required, so that a trained model's behaviour can discriminate between explanations. The crossing-order study on trained models is the first trained test on such a process.

4 Methodology

4.1 The synthetic processes and the exact oracle

Worlds. A 12×12 lattice with 4-neighbourhood, $N = 144$ states. The square has no identification; the cylinder is periodic in x. Ground-truth Betti numbers are computed from an explicit cubical complex over $\mathbb{F}_2$: square $\beta = (1, 0, 0)$, cylinder $(1, 1, 0)$. The primary metric is the intrinsic flat metric $d_M((x, y), (x', y')) = \sqrt{\min(|x - x'|, 12 - |x - x'|)^2 + (y - y')^2}$ on the cylinder (without the minimum on the square).

Dynamics. A lazy walk normalised by the maximal degree,

$$T_{ij} = \frac{1 - p_{\text{stay}}}{D_{\max}} \ (i \sim j), \qquad T_{ii} = 1 - \deg(i)\,\frac{1 - p_{\text{stay}}}{D_{\max}}, \qquad p_{\text{stay}} = 0.2,\ D_{\max} = 4, \tag{1}$$

which is symmetric and doubly stochastic, so the stationary law π is uniform.

Emissions. Four conditions (`docs/RESEARCH_SUMMARY.md` §4):

- **O** (main): 36 symbols with centres $c_{ab} = (0.5 + 2a, 0.5 + 2b)$ on a 6×6 grid, $E_{zj} \propto \exp(-d_M(z, c_j)^2/2\sigma^2)$, symbol names randomly permuted; $\sigma = 1.25$ was the first candidate to pass the generator-only calibration rule. O factorises exactly as $E^x[x, a]\, E^y[y, b]$.

- **P** (matched control): $E_P[(x,y)] = E_O[(\sigma_x(x), \sigma_y(y))]$ with fixed axis permutations, preserving rows, entropies, symbol marginals and the product structure while destroying spatial smoothness.
- **N** (negative control): $E_{zw} = 1/36$, nothing is learnable about the state.
- **U** (sanity control): one symbol per state ($V = 144$).

Sequences and the exact predictor. $z_1 \sim \pi$; for $t = 1, \ldots, 33$ emit $w_t \sim E[z_t]$ and transition. The model sees $[\mathrm{BOS}, w_1, \ldots, w_{32}]$ and predicts w_{t+1} at every position. The filter, in row vectors and float64, is

$$a_1 = \pi, \qquad b_t = \frac{a_t \odot E_{:,w_t}}{a_t E_{:,w_t}}, \qquad a_{t+1} = b_t T, \qquad q_t = b_t T E. \tag{2}$$

From it come $b^{(32)} = b_{32}$, the last-symbol posterior $b^{(1)} = r_{w_{32}}$ with $r_w = \pi \odot E_{:,w}/(\pi E_{:,w})$, the next-symbol law $F_1 = bTE$ and the two-symbol law $F_2[i,j] = b\,T\,\mathrm{diag}(E_{:,i})\,T\,E_{:,j}$. The *context gain* measures what the full history adds to the last symbol, and the *learning gate* measures how much of it the model captures:

$$G_C = \overline{\mathrm{KL}(q_C \,\|\, q_{\mathrm{last}})}, \qquad \mathrm{regret} = \overline{\mathrm{KL}(q_C \,\|\, p_{\mathrm{model}})}, \qquad \mathrm{captured} = 1 - \mathrm{regret}/G_C \;\geq\; 0.8. \tag{3}$$

Later studies reuse the same filter and sampler on other worlds: a 4×3 cylinder/Möbius seam band with a hidden world bit (the orientability studies), two 12×12 tori with a Dehn-twisted emission (the component-identity study), and a 4×4 torus carrying an S_3 local system (the crossing-order studies).

4.2 The transformer learners

Every trained model in the project uses the same pilot architecture (`docs/RESEARCH_SUMMARY.md` §6): a decoder-only pre-LN transformer [81, 83] with 4 blocks, $d = 128$, 4 heads, MLP width 512, GELU, learned positional embeddings, final LayerNorm, untied unembedding, no dropout, about 0.8M parameters (802,304 in the crossing-order study, with 18 output symbols). Training uses AdamW [50] with learning rate 10^{-3}, 200 warm-up steps, cosine decay, weight decay 0.1, clipping 1.0 and batch 128. The pilot trained for 5,000 updates on 131,072 trajectories per replicate, with checkpoints at 0, 50, 100, 200, 400, 700, 1,000, 1,500, 2,000, 3,000, 4,000 and 5,000; seeds 1729, 2718 and 3141 change data, initialisation, symbol names and batch order together. The primary hook is `resid_post_3`, the residual stream after the last block and before the final LayerNorm. The orientability study trained 10,000 updates (with optional direct joint heads for 2- and 3-symbol futures), and the crossing-order study 30,000 updates on 2^{20} histories per model.

4.3 Measurement: persistent homology and the F1 rule

For each replicate, eight disjoint panels of 512 test histories (one per trajectory, at position 32) are shared by every hook, checkpoint and space. On each cloud a Vietoris–Rips filtration over $\mathbb{F}_2$ in dimensions 0–1 is computed, and

$$S = \max_{\text{finite } H_1 \text{ bars}} \frac{\mathrm{death} - \mathrm{birth}}{s}, \qquad s = q_{95}\{d(x,x') > 0\}. \tag{4}$$

For replicate r and panel i, the contrast removes what the architecture produces at initialisation and what training produces in either world:

$$D_{r,i} = (S^{\mathrm{cyl}}_{\mathrm{final},i} - S^{\mathrm{cyl}}_{\mathrm{init},i}) - (S^{\mathrm{sq}}_{\mathrm{final},i} - S^{\mathrm{sq}}_{\mathrm{init},i}), \qquad u_r = \max_c q_{95}\{|S_{c,i} - S_{c,j}| : i < j\}, \tag{5}$$

with c ranging over the four cells. **F1 is supported** iff $D_{r,i} > 0$ in at least 7 of 8 panels in each of the three replicates, $\text{median}_i D_{r,i} > u_r$ for each replicate, and every model passed the learning gate; it is rejected iff all gates passed and a condition failed; otherwise it is inconclusive. H2 uses $\Delta_{\text{geom}} = \rho_s(d_A, d_{B32}) - \rho_s(d_A, d_{B1})$ over all pairs, and again over pairs with the same w_{32}, decided by sign consistency; distances on beliefs are Hellinger. Pair correlations are never significance tests.

4.4 Preregistration and frozen protocols

The pilot's hypotheses, measures and rules were committed in `PREREGISTRATION.md` after the oracle analysis and before any training; secondary analyses were registered blind in `PREREGISTRATION_X4.md`; every operational detail of the last pilot stage was fixed before any of its results existed. A change to a closed decision required my approval at a checkpoint; the one such change was the addition of the belief-alignment hypothesis H3′ before any result under P existed. Each follow-up protocol is frozen by its SHA-256 hash; coordinator addenda may fix implementation footprint or bindings but may not change a gate, threshold, seed or decision rule. Every frozen protocol contains a threshold register, an outcome taxonomy with a licensed sentence for each outcome, and an explicit "never licensed" list. Three-valued outcomes (PASS / INCONCLUSIVE / FAIL_TECHNICAL, or the study-specific equivalents) prevent a technical failure from being read as a negative finding. Since the counterfactual-forcing study, protocols also include a *tolerance-attainability* table fixed before data (§7), and since the four-symbol origin test an *oracle-scale check* that compares margins with what the oracle itself achieves (§6).

4.5 Dual-track planning and independent review

From 14 October I had every planning task done twice, independently, under a written planning protocol: one track by Codex in a read-only sandbox and the other by a clean-context Claude subagent, with identical request files and base commits and no access to each other's output. The coordinator wrote a merge document recording agreements, conflicts, the decision on each and what each track caught that the other missed. A third, result-blind LLM review (Codex, or a clean-context Claude reviewer when Codex was unavailable) had to return its required changes, and a confirmation pass had to return CONFIRM_FOR_FREEZE before any freeze. For example, the counterfactual-forcing protocol went through 13, then 7, then 4 required corrections; the trained crossing-order protocol through 14 required changes, including a verification of the empirical-Bernstein proof. The merge of the two counterfactual-forcing tracks found that half of one track's "random controls" exactly reproduced the primary intervention.

4.6 Independent test authors

For critical modules the tests are written from a written API contract (`API.md`) by a separate LLM author who never reads the implementation, and they are committed before the module enters the repository; the trained crossing-order study and the readout-attribution study used two independent authors. Corrections to an author's tests are made by the same author or a clean-context successor that reads only the governing ruling and the test, never module code. The implementer never writes the acceptance tests. The coordinator independently reruns the full test suite at each code freeze (e.g. 4,288 passed, 0 failed, at the code freeze of the trained crossing-order study).

4.7 Metered compute

Every scientific process runs under a meter that places the process tree in a Windows Job Object and records child CPU including exited descendants, meter CPU and a 0.1 s tail allowance per run into a store-local `cpu_ledger.json`. CPU is *measure-only* in the later studies (no CPU ceiling; a wall limit and memory limits guard against runaway jobs). The orientability training study revealed that its per-model supervisor had watched the virtual-environment launcher, not the training interpreter, so per-process CPU read about 0; the job-level meter was unaffected. A repair moved accounting to the whole process tree, and the crossing-order study's preflight checks that a deliberately over-limit child is killed with its training interpreter.

4.8 Registries against data leakage

A fresh test set is fresh only if none of its histories were ever generated, read or used for fitting in an earlier stage. From the counterfactual-forcing study onwards, each study builds an *exposure registry* of digests of every history that any earlier study could have exposed (3.36 million digests for the counterfactual-forcing study; 6,024,521 for the four-symbol origin test; about 19.7 million new ones plus the latter for the crossing-order study), and separation gates refuse a fresh pool with any collision. Reservations forbid any other history-generating job while a registry is being built. Test scratch directories inside the project root once made a registry inventory incomplete; scratch now lives outside the root.

4.9 Sealing until the decision stage

Quantities that could influence later choices are written to `sealed/` with their hashes and released only at the decision stage or at a stop. In the four-symbol origin test the validation means stayed sealed until the fresh result was recorded; in the trained crossing-order study the learnability-gate statistics, the learning curves and the headroom diagnostics were sealed, and the gate record released only PASS/FAIL/UNRESOLVED and the decision. Any model prediction on test histories before the decision stage is defined as leakage. This document follows the same rule: no model-performance number from that study was reported in earlier versions, and the numbers in §10.2.1 come only from the decision-stage report written after unsealing.

4.10 The technical-correction rules

A documented implementation or environment defect may be corrected by a coordinator ruling that names the defect, the correction commit, the affected artifacts and the evidence of independence from the outcome, with *at most two correction jobs per defect*. The failed attempt moves append-only to `superseded/<job>-a<k>/`; unaffected artifacts must regenerate bit-identically. A failure that shows a protocol statement to be wrong is not a defect: it stops the study and returns to planning. Any post-data change of a threshold or tolerance needs the owner. Environment reruns that reproduce identical values do not count as corrections, and final outcomes are never rerun.

5 The pilot

5.1 Validating the measurement on known topology

Question. Does the persistent-homology measurement detect a surface hole, as opposed to graph cycles? **Design.** A gate with thresholds fixed before any measurement: correct Betti numbers; $S_{\mathrm{cyl}} \geq 0.20$ and $S_{\mathrm{sq}} < 0.10$ on d_M; synthetic circle versus disk clouds ($M = 512$ in $\mathbb{R}^{128}$) classified correctly in at least 19 of 20 draws. **Result.** $S = 0.299$ (cylinder) and 0.037 (square) on d_M; 0.231

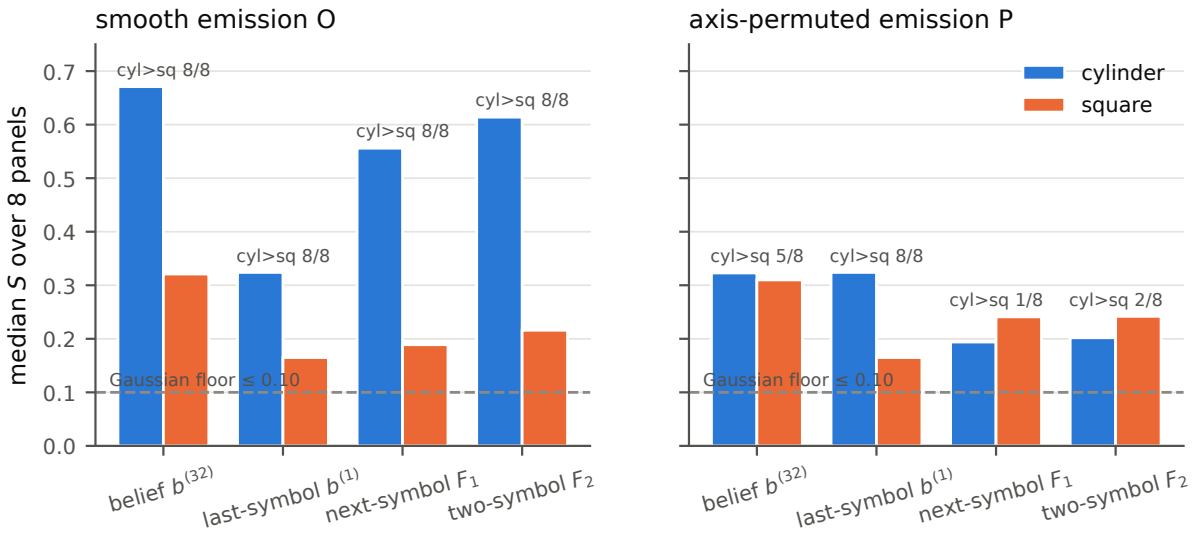


Figure 3: Oracle spaces, before any training: median S over eight panels in the exact (unlearned) spaces, replicate 1729, $\sigma = 1.25$, Hellinger distances; labels give the number of panels with $S_{\text{cyl}} > S_{\text{sq}}$. Source: `README.md`, section "Earlier exit (E1, no model)".

and 0.067 on the graph metric, although the transition graphs have 133 and 121 independent cycles; synthetic calibration 20/20 (mean circle S 0.460, maximum disk S 0.045). The gate passed (`reports/E0/summary.md`). **Lesson.** Graph cycles are not surface holes; the measurement targets the latter.

5.2 The topological difference exists in the exact belief

Question. Do the model-free spaces separate the worlds? **Result.** Under O every space separates the worlds in 8/8 panels, at 3–8 times the Gaussian floor; the full belief separates most strongly (0.671 vs 0.321). Under P the exact belief barely separates (5/8 panels), and the future spaces reverse (Figure 3). The last-symbol posterior and the emission field are identical under O and P, because P permutes states. **Interpretation.** RQ1 is decidable under O, and history strengthens the expected signature. But H3 ("the structure survives under P") became *one-sided* before any P model was trained: a failure under P would be expected even of the ideal predictor. This reading was registered before the P runs.

5.3 The main experiment under the smooth emission O

Design. Six runs (2 worlds × 3 seeds) plus one N model, 13–16 CPU minutes each. **What ran.** All six passed the learning gate (captured 0.985–0.986 for the cylinder and 0.992 for the square; regret 0.0018–0.0039 nats against $G_C = 0.2649$ / 0.2360). **Result.** F1 **supported**: $D > 0$ in 8/8 panels in each replicate, median $D = 0.158$, 0.176, 0.173 against $u_r = 0.097$, 0.084, 0.084 (Figure 4a). At initialisation the worlds are indistinguishable ($S \approx 0.06$); after training the cylinder reaches $S \approx 0.31$ and the square ≈ 0.13. H2 is sign-consistent: $\Delta_{\text{geom}} > 0$ in 48/48 panels over all pairs (medians 0.087–0.127), and among same-w_{32} pairs, where the last-symbol embedding is constant, the activation distances track $b^{(32)}$ with ρ_s 0.935–0.979. The N model sits at $H(W) = \ln 36$ (NLL 3.5835, half-width 0.0002): no leakage. In a secondary analysis over six views of the final state the F1 rule holds in all six, including the component the readout cannot see (`reports/E2/summary.md`). **The last-symbol limitation.** The trained embedding of the last symbol alone reproduces 0.89, 0.47 and 0.54 of the model's median D; the model-free mixing baselines (previous-token mixing and the context average) stay at ≤ 0.20 (Figure 4b). F1 alone

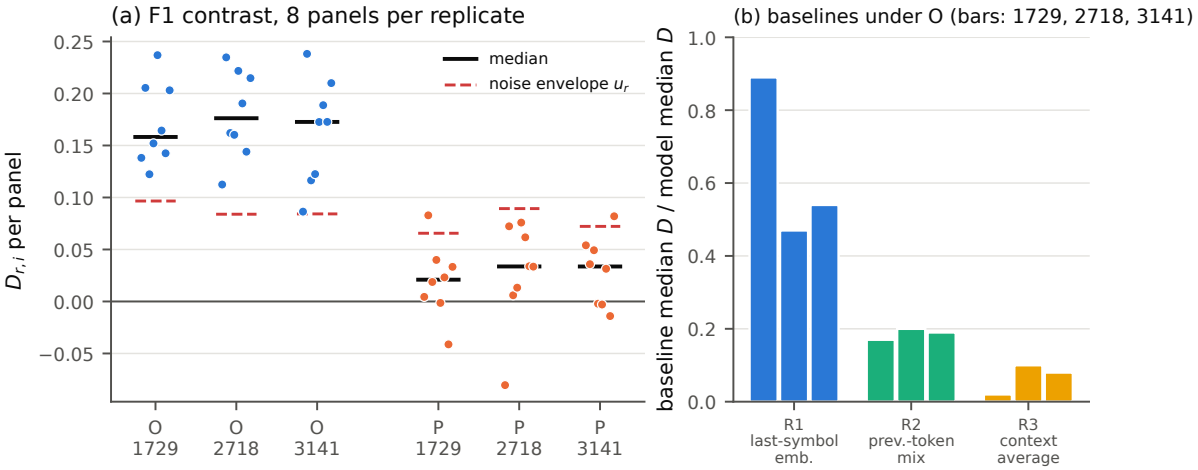


Figure 4: (a) F1 contrast $D_{r,i}$ per panel under O and P, with the median and the noise envelope u_r per replicate. (b) Fraction of the model's median D that each representation baseline reproduces under O. Sources: `reports/he_summary/data/d.json` (per-panel D, extracted read-only from the artifact store by `reports/he_summary/extract_data.py`); u_r and ratios from `reports/E2/summary.md` and `reports/E3/summary.md`.

therefore does not show that history integration produces the hole.

5.4 The permuted control P and training dynamics

P. All six P runs passed the learning gate (captured 0.874–0.914). The F1 rule was **rejected** (median D 0.021–0.034 below u_r 0.066–0.089; 6/8 and 5/8 positive panels in two replicates), which, as preregistered, is uninformative. The last-symbol-embedding contrast collapses under P (replicate 1729: 0.140 → −0.035), so its contrast under O is not static emission geometry; but whether it reflects history integration or learned symbol-level transition statistics remains open. **H3′ supported**: under P, $\rho_s(d_A, d_{B32})$ rises from 0.06–0.11 at initialisation to 0.70 and exceeds the better mixing baseline (0.39) in 48/48 run-panels. *Learned representations can align with Bayesian belief geometry even when the registered H_1 contrast is not supported*; an H_1 contrast is expected only when the belief geometry itself carries the hole.

H4 (timing). With t_h the first checkpoint where regret $< G_C$ and t_s the first where $S_t - S_0 > u_r$, all three cylinder runs under O had $t_h = 100$ and $t_s = 50$: **H4 rejected** (Figure 5). The early rise of S also occurs in the square, so it is not cylinder-specific. Exploratorily, the cylinder–square contrast on panel 1 grows mainly between steps 100 and 200 (+0.02 to +0.07 at step 50, +0.18 to +0.23 at step 200); the rule was written on raw S, not on the contrast, so this observation does not alter the verdict. A layer sweep shows the O contrast already at the embedding (≈ 0.105) and largest after the final LayerNorm (≈ 0.28), with P near zero at every hook (Figure 6).

5.5 Controls, probes, circular coordinates, sensitivity and a clean rerun

Controls. Two further N models sit at $\ln 36$ within 2×10^{-5}. The U models learn the visible-state dynamics (captured$_U$ 0.999) and also form an x-aligned circle (agreement 0.601), showing that symbol-level transition statistics alone can produce such a circle. **Probes.** Ridge probes fitted on dev panels decode $b^{(32)}$ from activations with test R^2 0.829 under O—no better than from the exact next-symbol law F_1 (0.838), far above initialisation (0.483) and the one-hot last symbol (0.421); the shuffled-label control is near zero (Figure 7a). The preregistered pattern (activations above all three competitors) held in 1/6 runs per condition. Under O the selected

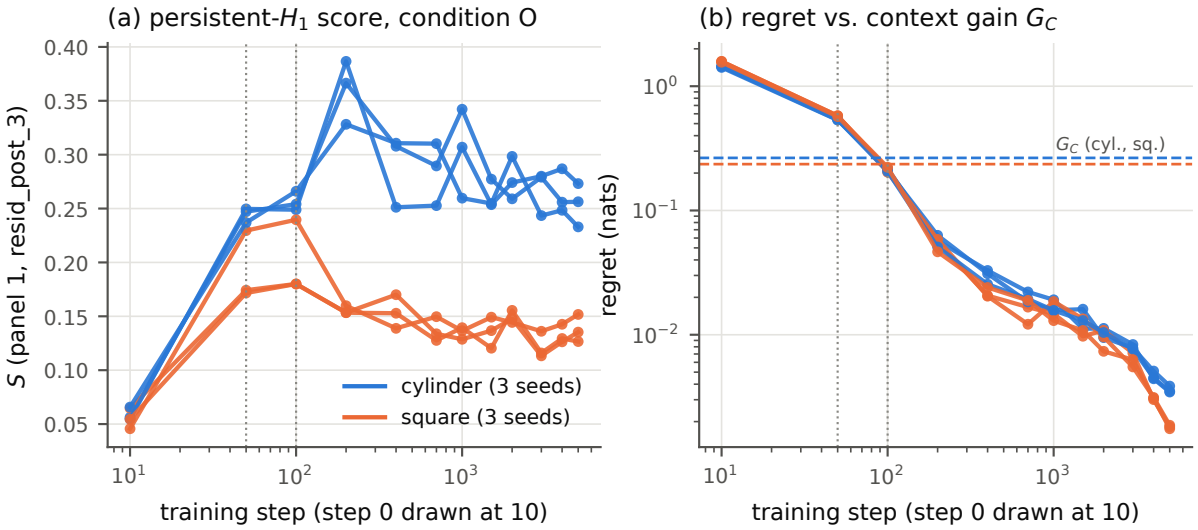


Figure 5: Training dynamics under O on panel 1: (a) the H_1 score S and (b) regret (log scale) at the twelve checkpoints, three seeds per world; dotted lines mark steps 50 and 100, dashed lines G_C. Sources: `reports/he_summary/data/dyn.json` (read-only extraction from the store, `reports/he_summary/extract_data.py`); G_C from `reports/E2/summary.md`.

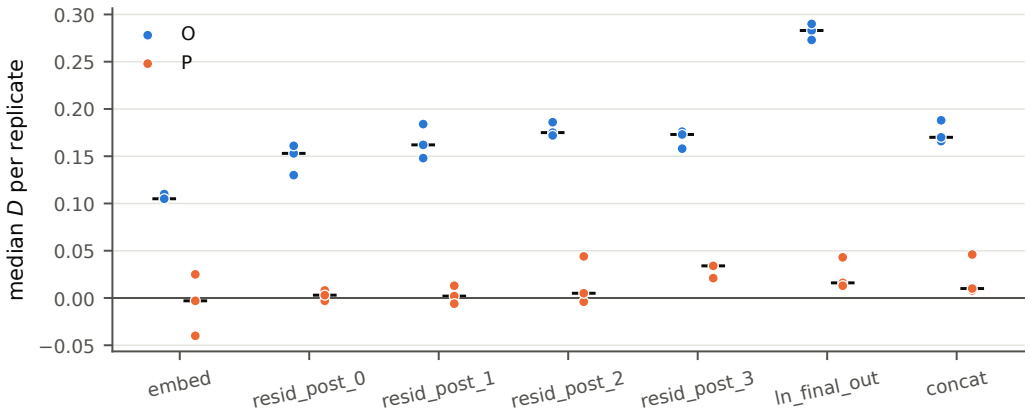


Figure 6: Layer sweep (descriptive): median D per replicate (dots) and its median (bar) for every hook, under O and P. Source: `reports/E3/summary.md`, table "Layer sweep".

ridge λ was the smallest grid value in every run, so R^2 may be slightly underestimated; the grid was frozen. **Circular coordinates.** From the leading H_1 cocycle (over $\mathbb{F}_{47}$, at mid-lifetime) a circular coordinate φ is computed and compared with the latent angle $\theta = 2\pi x(z_{32})/12$ by $A = \max(|\overline{e^{i(\varphi-\theta)}}|, |\overline{e^{i(\varphi+\theta)}}|)$. Cylinder models under O reach 0.884–0.892 (initialisation 0.06–0.12; non-periodic y 0.10; square 0.21–0.30; exact belief 0.915; Figure 7b). This identifies *which* loop F1 measures; it is privileged-evaluation and descriptive. A later diagnostic noted that the construction can silently give off-giant-component points an arbitrary offset; at most one point per panel was affected. **Sensitivity.** The verdicts are unchanged under the chord metric, dev-fitted PCA-32 and 256-history panels, and H3′ also under $\sqrt{\text{JSD}}$ (`reports/E4/summary.md` §6). **Clean rerun.** A fresh clone with an empty store reran the first four pipeline stages, including one full training: all 307 artifacts shared with the original store were reproduced bitwise, all six gate verdicts matched, store integrity (785/785) and report reproduction (9/9 byte-identical) passed. The clean-rerun gate nevertheless **failed**: one timing record of the original run did not exist, because the code that writes it was added after that run. The verdict stands as FAIL.

Lessons of the pilot. (i) A matched control must be evaluated on the oracle before training;

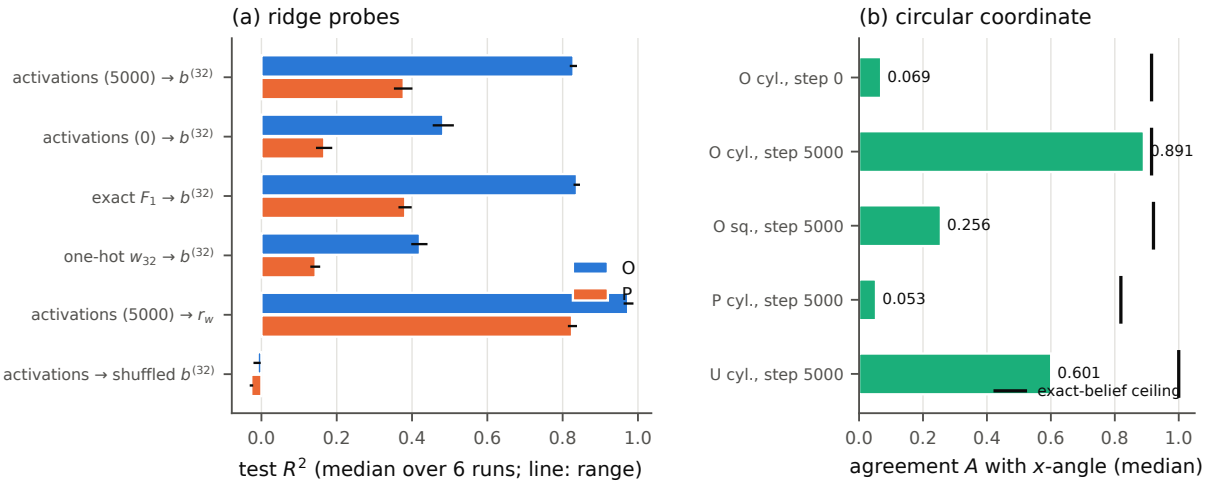


Figure 7: Probes and circular coordinates: (a) ridge-probe test R^2, median over six runs per condition with the range; (b) agreement of the circular coordinate with the latent x angle, with the exact-belief ceiling. Source: `reports/E4/summary.md` §4 and §5.

without the oracle analysis, the rejection under P would have been misread. (ii) Alignment with belief geometry and a topological contrast are different properties. (iii) The wording of a rule determines what it can find: H4 was written on S, the interesting timing was in the contrast. (iv) "Bitwise reproducible" and "gate passed" are not the same statement when a gate is defined over a complete store.

6 Origin of the circular structure (charter priority 1)

6.1 Circular-baseline audit

Question. Does the learned circle exceed what the last symbol permits? **Design.** Descriptive, on the pilot's already-unblinded final test panels. **Result.** In 24/24 panels the model's agreement (medians 0.884–0.892) exceeds an optimistic last-symbol bound (0.817) and the best available baseline (0.805): outcome BEYOND_SYMBOL_AND_MIXING. **Interpretation.** This closes the pilot's missing last-symbol comparison descriptively; it is not independent confirmation and not evidence of long-history origin.

6.2 How fast the circular posterior converges, and an eight-symbol cohort

Eight-symbol cohort. A preregistered cohort aimed to compare the learned phase with information beyond the last 8 symbols. Its oracle headroom gate failed: $B_8 = 0.00925$ with a one-sided 95% upper endpoint 0.00949, below the 0.01 margin. **Oracle suffix profile (exploratory).** For the first-harmonic target $m_K(h) = \mathbb{E}[c(z_{32}) \mid w_{33-K:32}]$, $c(z) = (\cos 2\pi x/12, \sin 2\pi x/12)$,

$$B_K = \mathbb{E}\,\|m_{32} - m_K\|, \qquad K \in \{1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32\}, \tag{6}$$

was 0.369, 0.198, 0.067, 0.0092, 0.00018 and 0 on calibration (validation nearly identical; Figure 8a). All bootstrap intervals were recomputed independently. The coordinator's review corrected the worker's report: "only at $K \leq 4$" means only among evaluated grid points, and "this world cannot support memory beyond about 8" is not an accepted conclusion. **Lesson.** The circular posterior converges quickly with suffix length, so any history-origin experiment needs a small K.

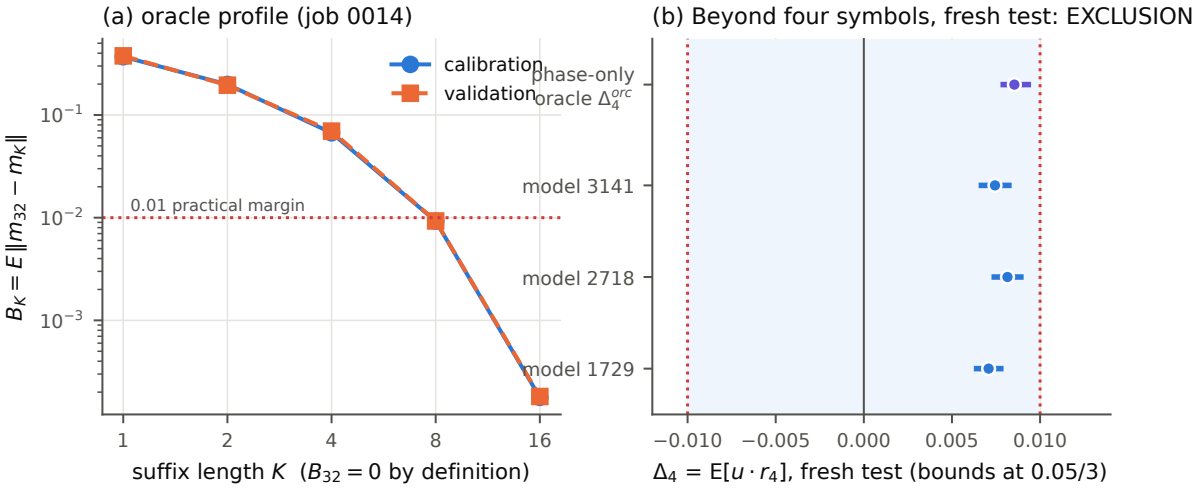


Figure 8: (a) Oracle profile B_K for the first-harmonic circular posterior (calibration and validation); $B_{32} = 0$ by definition. (b) Four-symbol origin test, fresh-test result: per model the nominal one-sided bounds $[L, U]$ (rank-84 and rank-4,917 bootstrap order statistics) and point estimate of Δ_4, the EXCLUSION margin ± 0.01 (dotted), and the phase-only oracle comparator Δ_4^{orc}. Sources: `agent-handoff/jobs/0014/review.md`; `agent-handoff/jobs/0057/review.md`.

6.3 Origin beyond the last four symbols, first attempt: the frozen chart rule fails

Design. This study moved to $K = 4$ with a frozen circular-chart construction (the midpoint scale of the longest H_1 bar, landmark graph, integer lift). **What ran.** Identity and the exact process/oracle gates passed (moment errors $\leq 8 \times 10^{-16}$). **Result.** INCONCLUSIVE at chart_ calibration: at the frozen scale the landmark graph of model 1729 was disconnected; by rule, no retry, no refit and no scoring. Because the first counterfactual-forcing protocol depended on this chart by its own freeze, it was blocked at the same moment. A frozen geometry-only diagnostic then found that the disconnection was a single isolated smallest-norm point and that the largest connected component held at least 99.8% of landmarks in all six cases (GO). I approved a new rule (the largest component, gated at $\geq 95\%$) for future studies only; the first attempt stayed closed.

6.4 Origin beyond the last four symbols: does the learned phase covary with that information?

Question. In the pilot's three cylinder models under O (step 5000, `resid_post_3`, position 32), does the circular coordinate $u_j(h) = (\cos\varphi_j, \sin\varphi_j)$ built by the new chart rule on fresh landmarks covary with $r_4 = m_{32} - m_4$, the part of the first-harmonic belief that the last four observations do not determine? **Estimand.** $\Delta_4 = \mathbb{E}[u \cdot r_4]$. By the tower property $\Delta_4 = 0$ for every suffix-only coordinate. Rows without chart support contribute the interval $[-\|r_4\|, +\|r_4\|]$, so $[\mathbb{E}X^-, \mathbb{E}X^+]$ is exactly the identified set over all completions. **Decision.** Per model, SUPPORT iff $L(\mathbb{E}X^-) - F > 0.01$; EXCLUDE iff $U(\mathbb{E}X^+) + F < 0.01$ and $L(\mathbb{E}X^-) - F > -0.01$, with one-sided bounds at 0.05/3 and a numerical margin $F = \max(B_{\text{num}}, 10^{-9}) + Z_{\text{bound}}$ that makes the claim concern the documented law. **What ran.** The calibration and validation stage needed three technical corrections, each within the two-per-defect rule: a dictionary passed to `Fraction`, a byte-order mark and a lazy sequence in the registry handoff, and a missing reader for the store's own superseded digests; no outcome-bearing quantity existed at any failure point. Validation then passed every gate (support 3072/3072 in every model, oracle-headroom lower bound 0.0636) and fixed $N = 3072$ test rows. **Result.** On the fresh test, **EXCLUDE in all three models**: $[L, U]$

= [0.00640, 0.00777], [0.00740, 0.00891], [0.00667, 0.00823] (Figure 8b). Suffix-only nulls were near zero, as designed.

Interpretation and caveat. The licensed sentence is that, for this chart rule, site and process, a covariance of either sign at or beyond 0.01 is excluded. But the phase-only oracle comparator itself achieves only $\Delta_4^{grc} = 0.00854$ [0.00791, 0.00933], below the margin, and the models reach 83–95% of it; all lower bounds are positive. EXCLUSION therefore means only that the covariance is small in absolute terms; it does not show that the learned phase lacks beyond-four-symbol information. The protocol registered no "positive but below margin" status, so no stronger claim is licensed. **Lesson.** Margins must be checked against the oracle's own achievable value before freezing; the trained crossing-order and readout-attribution protocols adopted this as an oracle-scale check.

6.5 Component identity beyond short windows (oracle only)

Question. In a process whose components have identical single-symbol statistics, how much component information is available from short windows versus the full history, and is the full history more than a product of block likelihoods? **Design.** Two 12×12 tori with the pilot walk; component B emits A's field pulled back by the Dehn twist $\phi(x, y) = (x + y \bmod 12, y)$; exact enumeration for windows up to 4 and 2^{20} validated Monte Carlo sequences otherwise. **Result.** GO (full history needed, non-additively): the last symbol carries no component information; window information rises from 0.002 nats (2 symbols) to 0.067 (8) and 0.325 (full history); full-history Bayes accuracy exceeds the 8-window accuracy by 0.191 (99% interval [0.190, 0.192]) and a four-block likelihood product by 0.0567 [0.0562, 0.0571], above the 0.03 threshold; a local-noise control was nearly additive (0.008). **Interpretation.** GO licenses *designing* a trained stage only, about component identity rather than the circular coordinate; short windows are not blind. It motivated the search for a construction where short windows are *exactly* blind, which became the crossing-order studies (§10).

6.6 A sweep of worlds with more history to measure (oracle only)

Question. The origin test beyond four symbols registered a margin of 0.01 that the oracle's own beyond-four quantity in the pilot world (0.0085) does not reach. Is there a cylinder world, close to the pilot's, in which that quantity is at least three times the margin, and in which context helps next-symbol prediction enough that a model could plausibly learn it? **Design.** Oracle only: nothing is trained and no model is run. The grid has 225 worlds: the walk's stay probability (0.2 to 0.9375), the emission width (1.25 to 3), circular aliasing of the symbols (one to three levels) and the circumference (8, 12 or 16), with height 12 and histories of 32 symbols. Exact filters removed worlds whose symbol maps are reflection- or translation-symmetric (75) and worlds whose circle is not legible (43). The rest were screened on 4,096 rows each, and 16 finalists were confirmed on 32,768 fresh rows with simultaneous lower bounds ($\alpha = 0.05/16$). A world qualifies if four lower bounds hold: the beyond-four signal (the oracle comparator of the origin test) is at least 0.03; the context gain is at least 0.10 nats; the beyond-four predictive gain is at least the pilot world's value and at least 0.0078 nats; and the same holds for the circular part of the symbol. Among qualified worlds the smallest departure from the pilot world wins. **What ran.** The known-case stage needed three attempts. A scope check stopped the first before anything was sampled. A known case failed the second by one rounding unit on a constant input, which I settled by decision. The third passed. The sweep itself then passed every stage in 15 minutes. The study used 0.54 CPU-hours in all, including tests. **Result** (`hws-store/stages/FINAL/REPORT.json`). SELECTED, at the lowest departure tier: the same 12×12 cylinder and the same walk (stay probability 0.2), with emission width 1.75 instead of 1.25, so no new observation code is needed. On the fresh confirmation rows the beyond-four signal is 0.0470 (lower bound 0.0458; pilot world 0.0085), 4.7

times the margin. The lower bounds of the context gain, the beyond-four predictive gain and its circular part are 0.283, 0.031 and 0.018 nats, against floors of 0.10, 0.012 and 0.006. **Licence.** This is an oracle property of one world. It says nothing about whether a model trained there learns the world or would carry the signal; that was the question of the training pilot and the full test (§6.7).

6.7 Origin beyond four symbols in the new world: a pilot and a full test

Training pilot. Two small models were trained in the selected world with the pilot's recipe; only the emission width changed. Known cases first reproduced the original training run bit for bit and checked the oracle and the law bound. Both models learned, the frozen chart rule built a circle in each that passed calibration and validation on fresh histories, and each model's capture of the beyond-four signal reached the registered minimum for a full test at 80% planned power (outcome PASS, 28 October). The pilot fixed the full test's size (three new models, at least 3,072 test rows) and its cost forecast through registered rules only. Its own statistics are uncertified and computed on models that never enter the full test, so they are not reported. It used 1.86 CPU-hours.

Full test: question and design. In three new models (training seeds 620301–620303, 5,000 updates each, the pilot's architecture and recipe, `resid_post_3`, position 32) trained in the selected world, does the learned chart phase covary with $r_4 = m_{32} - m_4$, the part of the first-harmonic belief that the last four observations do not determine? The estimand, the chart rule (largest component $\geq 95\%$), the identified-set treatment of rows without chart support, the one-sided bounds at $0.05/3$, the numerical margin F and the decision rule are those of the four-symbol origin test (§6), with the same margin 0.01: per model, SUPPORT iff $L(\mathbb{E}X^{-}) - F > 0.01$. Nothing about the threshold, the margin, the chart parameters or the recipe was changed in response to any earlier result; the pilot entered only through its registered handoff. The full test needed my explicit run approval, given on 29 October.

What ran. Known cases (bit-for-bit reproduction of the training run, the law bound, a full rehearsal of the exposure registry) passed at the third attempt: two code defects stopped the first two before any model was trained, and each was corrected under the two-per-defect rule with the test suites and the synthetic dry run repeated. The three models trained one after another and all passed the registered learning gate. Validation passed every gate: each model's chart was a single 512-landmark component, chart support was 3,072 of 3,072 rows in every model, and the test size was fixed at $N = 3072$. Two further defects were corrected on the way, neither touching any outcome-bearing quantity: the release check of the validation stage ran outside the study's binding, and the meter's output cap (a resource setting) was too small for the second exposure registry and was raised from 4 to 16 GiB.

Result (`hwsc-store/stages/S8/RESULT.json`). **SUPPORT in all three models.** On 3,072 fresh test histories the bounds $[L, U]$ of $\mathbb{E}[u \cdot r_4]$ after the margin F are [0.0406, 0.0476], [0.0395, 0.0454] and [0.0402, 0.0469] for the three models; every lower bound is about four times the margin. The oracle comparator on the same rows is $\Delta_4^{orc} = 0.0473$, and the models' lower-envelope estimates $\mathbb{E}X^{-}$ reach 0.925, 0.894 and 0.918 of it. Support was complete, and the decoder control was certified with its lower bound near zero (-0.003). The step-0 (untrained) chart control was unavailable for two models (registered annotations INIT_UNAVAILABLE for the second and third model); by rule this does not change the outcome.

Licence. The registered licence reads: on its supported rows, this coordinate is not a function of the last four observations; it depends on earlier observations, in a direction aligned with the oracle belief residual. Every function of the last four observations has zero covariance with r_4 under the documented law, so a lower bound above the margin cannot come from a suffix-only coordinate. **What it does not establish.** The claim is about these three trained models in this one world (three draws of the training process, not a seed population). It says nothing about the

pilot models, the fallback worlds or the original pilot world: the earlier EXCLUSION there stands, and SUPPORT here does not imply that those models lacked the information, since their world had too little of it to see. The stage-A oracle numbers motivated the world choice and are not part of the evidence. The full list of registered qualifiers is in the result file.

6.8 When does the beyond-four signal appear during training?

Question and design. The full test read its three models at the end of training. This follow-up asks when, during training, the learned chart phase starts to carry the beyond-four-symbol part of the belief, relative to two landmarks: the first checkpoint whose chart passes the full test's validation rule, and the registered learning landmark (the captured score first reaching 0.8). It reuses the 12 checkpoints saved during each training run (steps 0, 50, 100, 200, 400, 700, 1000, 1500, 2000, 3000, 4000 and 5000), draws its own fresh histories, builds a chart at every checkpoint by the full test's rule, and bounds the same covariance with the same margin 0.01. Six statements and their error rates were registered before any checkpoint was read; "before" and "after" readings use stronger bounds (level 1/720 per side and checkpoint, 1/60 per model). I approved the run on 2 November; it used 3.19 CPU-hours in its store ledger (7.08 in its study ledger, which also counts test and dry-run repeats after corrections).

Result (`hwsd-store/stages/SUMMARY/REPORT.json`). All gates passed and the registered outcome is a full report of the six statements:

- The step-5000 result of the full test replicates on these fresh histories in all three models (TRUE).
- "Not before a validated chart" is FALSE: in the second and third model, at step 100, a chart that had not yet passed validation already carried the covariance above 0.01 at the strong level; their first validated charts came at steps 400 and 200. In the first model the statement holds (TRUE, informative).
- "Only after the chart forms" is FALSE in all three: the first validated chart (steps 200, 400, 200) already carried it.
- "Only after the learning landmark" is FALSE in all three: the covariance was already above 0.01 when the captured score first reached 0.8.
- When the predictions first beat every predictor that sees only the last four symbols (step 400 in all three), the chart phase already carried it (TRUE).
- No model showed a certified loss after a certified gain (TRUE; this does not mean monotone).

Relative to the first validated chart the order is WITH in the first model and BEFORE in the other two; relative to the learning landmark it is the same.

What it does not establish. It makes no use claim (§7.5 asks that). Checkpoints of one run are not independent experiments, and there is no counterfactual, so training is not shown to cause anything. Timing is resolved only to the checkpoint grid. The BEFORE readings rest on charts that had not passed validation; their bounds are valid for that fixed field, but the field itself is not certified. It covers three runs of one recipe in one world. The six statements are not independent confirmations.

6.9 Does the result hold in other worlds?

Question and design. The full test (§6.7) answered the origin question in one world. This study asks whether that answer is a property of training rather than of that world: in worlds with different amounts of beyond-four-symbol information, do models trained by the same recipe

carry it, and do they capture a similar fraction of what the oracle carries? It repeats the full test unchanged (recipe, estimand, certificate, margin 0.01, decision rule, 3,072 fresh test histories per world) in three new worlds. The worlds were chosen before any data by a rule fixed in the plan from the world sweep's oracle records only: among the sweep's finalists with an exact law bound, the ones with the lowest, the highest and the geometric-middle lower bound of the oracle's beyond-four signal. This gave a lazy walk with sharp emissions ("lo", bound 0.036), a world near the selected one ("mid", 0.086), and the world with the broadest emissions ("hi", 0.232), a 6.4-fold span around the selected world's 0.046 (`hwsg-store/stages/O/O_RECORD.json`). Three new models were trained per world with fresh seeds, and every world had its own known-case, oracle, learnability and chart gates. A secondary quantity is each model's capture: its covariance as a fraction of the oracle comparator on the same test rows, with a registered floor of one half. A claim for all worlds required SUPPORT in all three.

Result (`hwsg-store/stages/CROSS/CROSS.json`; `hwsg-store/worlds/<world>/stages/S8/RESULT.json`).

- **lo: SUPPORT in all three models.** Lower bounds 0.031–0.033 against the margin 0.01; capture 0.92–0.96 of the oracle comparator (mean 0.946).
- **mid: SUPPORT in all three models.** Lower bounds 0.072–0.079; capture 0.87–0.93 (mean 0.911).
- **hi: INCONCLUSIVE (chart unavailable).** All three models passed the learnability gate, but for one of them the registered chart rule gave no chart that passed validation on fresh histories (fidelity 0.517 against the required 0.80; the other two reached 0.94 and 0.97). The plan registered this risk in advance: the world is reported as inconclusive, and no model, recipe or chart rule was replaced.
- **Across worlds.** No claim for all worlds is available, since the registered rule needs all three. Every one of the six models that reached the endpoint captures at least half of the oracle comparator. The two worlds' mean captures differ by 0.035; by the registered descriptive check they are not compatible with one common fraction at the reported precision.

Before any test value was computed, the coordinator's checks found two wiring defects in the test-stage code (a part the rehearsal had never run end to end), and one stage stopped on a certificate defect; each was corrected, re-tested and re-frozen. A defect in the coordinator's record-keeping gave one world's endpoint a wrong label; the rerun reproduced every number bit for bit and only corrected the label. No threshold, margin or setting changed.

What it does not establish. Nothing about the third world: an unavailable chart is not evidence that its models lack the information. Nothing about worlds outside the sweep's grid, other recipes, sizes, sites or architectures, or any trend of capture with the world's parameters, and no pooled estimate across worlds. The untrained-chart comparator was unavailable for five of the six models (a registered annotation). The study makes no use claim. Its store ledger holds 6.27 CPU-hours; its study ledger, which also counts the nine trainings (about 0.8–0.9 CPU-hours each) and every test and dry-run repeat, holds 15.6 (`agent-handoff/HWSG_CPU_LEDGER.json`).

7 Causal use (charter priority 2)

7.1 Erasing the circular coordinate

Design. Erase the direction carrying the coordinate m_{32} at the final site and compare the damage to prediction with random erasers matched in damage. **Result.** The targeted eraser removed linear recoverability, but a fixed RBF decoder still recovered the coordinate at 0.998 (LINEAR_COMPONENT_ONLY), and 0 of 10,000 random erasers fell inside the frozen damage-

matching window (FAMILY_UNMATCHED). The causal endpoint was not run: INCONCLUSIVE (`docs/proposals/X4F_COORDINATOR_REVIEW_ADDENDUM.md`). **Lesson.** The circular information is nonlinearly and redundantly encoded; linear erasure cannot test its use.

7.2 Counterfactual state forcing

Question. At `resid_post_3`, position 32, of the pilot's cylinder models under O, where only the final LayerNorm and unembedding follow, does the readout map a change of the learned chart phase into a change of the predictive distribution in the direction an exact counterfactual oracle prescribes? Because the unembedding has rank at most 35, the residual-to-output Jacobian has a kernel of dimension at least 93, so the test is not trivial. **Design.** Donors $H_{\pm}$ shift the oracle state along the circle; a Frisch–Waugh–Lovell phase map fitted on calibration rows defines the forced state; 32 Haar-random whitened 2-frames form the matched control family; gates bound damage to the decoded last symbol $\hat{w}$ and the decoded y-marginal, support, registration of the counterfactual, a positive control, and a numerical certificate of every oracle row. The first version was blocked by the chart failure of §6; a revised version (C1′) replaced that dependency with the largest-component chart rule (33 anchored edits). **What ran.** The oracle stage first failed technically (an integer/string key mismatch), then passed every gate on bit-identical histories: the exact belief predicts the forced-state effect with a one-sided lower bound of 1.12 nats of mean gain, far above 0.01. The calibration stage first failed at a ridge-equivalence self-check; a coordinator ruling relaxed that tolerance after oracle-stage data existed, and the rerun reached the damage gate. **Result.** INCONCLUSIVE (no matched control family) at the calibration damage gate in all three models. The primary intervention flipped the decoded w_{32} on 29–39% of rows ($D_w(T) =$ 0.311, 0.389, 0.286 against a ceiling of 0.02) and shifted the decoded y-marginal by 2.5–3.2 times its calibration variance (ceiling 0.05), while the matched controls barely moved $\hat{w}$ (< 0.001); only 6, 0 and 4 of 32 frames matched, against 28 required. The coordinator found no implementation defect: the gap is a property of the fitted direction, not of displacement size. **Governance flag.** That ruling changed a tolerance after data existed, without my prior approval, in tension with the protocol's own rules. The damage-gate values do not depend on it (charts and earlier gate values are bit-identical), and under a strict reading the outcome would have been FAIL_TECHNICAL at the self-check, which licenses the same "assay infeasible as specified". I ratified the ruling afterwards. Since then every protocol carries a tolerance-attainability table fixed before data.

Interpretation for RQ3. Neither design scored a causal endpoint. Both failures tell me about the instruments and nothing about use: the information is nonlinear, and the obvious linear intervention direction is entangled with the last-symbol readout.

7.3 Readout attribution of the circle code

Question. For natural pairs of histories that differ in their x-history but share the last symbol, what share of the model's own oracle-aligned change in next-symbol prediction is carried by an interchange of its registered circle code at the final position? **Design.** After the final LayerNorm the head is exactly linear, so this attribution is exact and needs no synthetic state passed through a nonlinearity, which removes the failure mode of the forcing study at its root. The code is the 6-dimensional span of the first three harmonics of the learned chart phase, made nuisance-excluding by a generalised-least-squares projector; a secondary family repeats the interchange at layer 2. The share ψ is declared USED if its lower bound exceeds 0.50 and NOT_USED if its upper bound is below 0.10 together with a bound on the total effect; claims need two of the three models. **What ran.** After two independent plans, a comparison, a merge and three rounds of result-blind review I froze the protocol on 21 October, revised it once before any data existed (a translation placebo on the y-axis replaced a reflection that failed on this process), and authorised execution on 22 October. The first stage needed four attempts: the first three stopped at entry checks before

anything was sampled (a release-record field name; a lineage check that refused the stage's own entry records; then the same check refusing the compute meter's own lock file), and each defect was corrected under the two-per-defect rule. From then on all five stages passed every gate on 26 October: identity, registry and separation, the exact oracle with Decimal reference rows, eligibility (coverage 0.96 for x, 0.88–0.90 for y, reproducing a synthetic dry run count for count), model identity, the generalised-least-squares fits with an 80-digit reference, chart, link and registration screens on a separate sample, the validation gates (the models respond, the y placebo stays below its registered bound), and a precision ladder that fixed 4,096 fresh test rows. The whole study used 0.87 CPU-hours.

Result (fresh test, 4,096 rows; `c2-readout-store/stages/S5/report.json`). **USED** in all three models: $\hat{\psi} = 0.851$, 0.854 and 0.856, with one-sided lower bounds of $\mathbb{E}[A_S - 0.50\,A_{\text{full}}]$ of 0.354–0.363 nats, far above zero; the models respond to the counterfactual (θ_{full} 0.95–0.96 against 0.30). The six-dimensional code carries $\psi \approx 0.85$ of the response, while exact random six-dimensional planes of the 127-dimensional readout space carry about 0.03–0.12; the nuisance directions carry about 0.001, and the rest about 0.145. Its effect is almost entirely visible to the readout. The Euclidean complement and the one- and two-harmonic codes give the same outcome, so no projector or harmonic qualifier applies. The layer-2 code interchange is UPSTREAM_USED: the full layer-2 interchange transmits essentially the whole natural contrast ($\hat{\tau}_M \approx 1.006$), and the registered layer-2 code carries 0.84 of it, residual skip included. The code built from the oracle's own phase is also USED ($\hat{\psi} = 0.87$). The validation values, opened only after the test outcome, agree to about 0.005.

Licence and reading. The outcome concerns the frozen, nuisance-excluding linear code defined by the fit and projector; it does not exclude predictive use of phase information in excluded directions, higher harmonics, interactions or other encodings, and it does not show that the code is the only carrier. Within that scope, the next-symbol readout at the final position uses the learned circle code for most of its response to the x-history. The protocol stated USED as the expected outcome, so this result confirms an expectation rather than reporting a surprise. The second-to-last symbol changes with the rest of the x-history in every counterfactual pair, so the result does not separate long history from that symbol.

7.4 Is the circle code necessary, and can the method say "not used"?

Questions. (i) Necessity: if everything except the registered code is taken from the other history (the complement interchange), how much of the response moves? (ii) Specificity: on a model whose code is present but provably unread, does the same frozen method return NOT_USED? **Design.** At the final readout the head is exactly linear, so the complement share equals one minus the code share. It mirrors the previous result rather than adding independent evidence, but here it is measured on fresh histories. "Necessary" (a complement share below 0.10) was therefore not expected; the expected outcome was "code dominant" (a complement share between 0.10 and 0.50). A second family tests necessity at layer 2, where the remaining computation is non-linear. For specificity, decoy models change only the output (unembedding) matrix. The code's directions are removed from the readout and the rest is multiplied by a fixed gain of 6. The code then stays bitwise in the activations, its readout is exactly zero, and the decoy still responds to the counterfactual. The method re-estimates the code on a fresh split, and constructed known cases check it on real activations first. **What ran.** The study was frozen and authorised on 27 October after five synthetic dry runs, which exposed and corrected several defects in the code and its rehearsal fixtures. In the execution, one attempt at the first stage was lost when its background process died before drawing any data. A later stage started too early and was set aside. Both were rerun, and all five stages passed every gate. The study used about 5.0 CPU-hours, including tests and dry runs; the real stages took 1.1. **Result** (`c2nd-store/stages/S5/report.json`; a fresh test of 4,096 rows). Necessity: CODE_DOMINANT in all three models. The complement carries

0.149, 0.146 and 0.144 of the signed oracle-aligned response, so the code is the main carrier of this readout response but not the only one. The registered qualifiers record that this outcome depends on the projector and on the first harmonic. At layer 2 the code is also dominant (complement 0.145, 0.149 and 0.147; interaction share 0.01–0.02, descriptive). Decoys: DECOY_NOT_USED in all three. The method returned code shares of 0.028, 0.026 and 0.020, while the decoys still responded at 0.83–0.84 of the oracle contrast through other directions, and every core known case returned its constructed answer. Without the gain the decoys fail the response gate, as designed. **Reading.** The earlier USED verdict does not come from a method that always says "used": on models where the code is present but unread, it says "not used". Taken together, the registered code carries about 85% of the readout response and everything else 14–15%, and the measure is specific on the constructed decoys. The limits stand: only the frozen linear code is covered, an exact identity ties necessity to the earlier share, and only the constructed decoys were tested.

7.5 Do the new models' predictions use history beyond four symbols?

Question and design. The full test in the selected world (§6.7) showed that the learned chart phase of three new models carries information from beyond the last four symbols. This study asks whether their predictions depend on it, and how much of that dependence runs through the circle code. It uses pairs of natural histories that share their last four symbols; each arm is a draw from the process. Any predictor that depends only on the last four symbols responds identically to both arms, so any difference comes from earlier history. The response θ of a model is the part of its change in next-symbol prediction (position 32) that is aligned with the oracle's change, as a fraction of the oracle's own discrimination between the two arms. The bars are those I approved for the readout-attribution study, unchanged (0.10 and 0.30), with one-sided bounds at $1 - 1/300$ and a family-wise error at most 0.05. The models, site and charts are those of the full test.

Oracle-only stage. Before any model was opened, an oracle-only stage checked on fresh pairs that both questions could be answered with the registered precision. The response question could: the oracle's own discrimination averaged 0.0646 nats, with a lower bound of 0.0628, about three times the registered minimum of 0.02. The share question could not: one of the share quantities missed its required precision at every registered sample size, so by the registered rule the share family was dropped before any model was measured (outcome INCONCLUSIVE/ORACLE_FEASIBILITY for the share). I approved this stage on 1 November; the first attempt stopped at its CPU pause line inside a slow exposure search, and after that search was corrected the rerun passed on 2 November (`hwsu-store/OF_ACCEPT.json`).

Model stage. I approved the model stage on 3 November. Its known cases passed at the fourth attempt; the first three stopped on configuration and procedure defects, each corrected (with a re-freeze where code changed) before any model output was computed. Validation passed every gate (4,096 pairs, one block), the second exposure registry passed, and the test on 4,096 fresh pairs passed every gate.

Result (`hwsu-store/stages/E2/REPORT.json`). **RESPONDS in all three models.** The estimated responses are $\hat{\theta} = 0.934$, 0.883 and 0.923 (descriptive 95% intervals 0.919–0.948, 0.870–0.896, 0.910–0.936). The registered bounds on the response in excess of 0.30 of the oracle's discrimination are 0.041, 0.037 and 0.040, all above zero, and those in excess of 0.10 are 0.053, 0.050 and 0.052. The known-case controls on the test pairs returned their constructed categories. Descriptively, the model and the oracle move in the same direction on 99.3% of pairs, and the effect is heavy-tailed (the top 1% of pairs carry 13% of it).

Licence. The registered licence reads: in 3 of the 3 models, when only the history before the last four symbols changes, the next-symbol prediction at position 32 moves in the direction of the oracle's change by more than 0.30 of the oracle's own discrimination; a predictor reading only the last four symbols would show zero on these pairs. The prediction therefore depends on earlier

history, aligned with the belief. **What it does not establish.** How much of the response runs through the circle code was not assessed; this is no evidence for or against use of the code. The study does not exclude other encodings of the same information, and it covers these three models, one position and one world. The study used 1.83 CPU-hours in its store ledger (4.73 in its study ledger, which also counts test and dry-run repeats).

8 Necessity and prediction horizons (charter priority 3)

8.1 Two-step-ahead distinctions in the pilot world

Question. Are there reachable beliefs that agree in F_1 but differ in F_2, so that an ideal predictor must represent more than the next-symbol law? **Result.** The ambient tangent ranks allow it ($Q_1 = 35$, $Q_2 = 137$), but the four old pools were undercovered (49–66 eligible anchors against 128 required): INCONCLUSIVE. Four fresh pools (159/141/159/156 anchors) gave **zero** witnesses: a scoped NO-GO for the practical horizon gap at those thresholds and that resolution. It is not a universal sufficiency theorem; the planned next phase was not run.

8.2 An orientability distinction needed only two steps ahead (oracle)

Design. A minimal 4×3 seam band, cylinder or Möbius, with a hidden world bit Z (prior $\frac{1}{2}$); five tokens $\sigma_0, \sigma_2, \sigma_3, A, B$. Theorems in the frozen protocol: at every decision position ($w_t = \sigma_3$) the next-symbol law is identical in both worlds; at horizon 2 the world-conditional laws differ only in four entries. **What ran.** Exact rational enumeration of all 37,190 reachable histories up to length 8, a float oracle agreeing to 4×10^{-15}, and an 80-digit Decimal reference on 650 histories. **Result.** PASS: every pre-stated exact value was reproduced, including the posterior-isolation pair (identical location beliefs, world posteriors $\frac{1}{4}$ vs $\frac{3}{4}$, identical next-symbol law, two-step TV $\frac{1}{100}$). **Licence.** An existence result about an orientability distinction (equal Betti numbers) at reachable histories; nothing about the square and cylinder, β_1, or trained models.

8.3 Orientability in trained models: do transformers carry the world posterior?

Question. At decision positions, how much of $\pi(h) = P(Z = M \mid h)$ is recoverable from the activation, and how does it depend on the training objective horizon $H \in \{1, 2, 3\}$ and on the in-context decision position $t \in \{16, 28\}$? **Design.** 4 paired seeds $\times$ 3 horizons plus 2 null models (14 models, 10,000 updates); two Bonferroni-controlled confirmatory contrasts; a 2-model learnability gate first. At band-edge positions the oracle contrast $d_i = 2(a/4)(\pi - \frac{1}{2})(\delta_M - \delta_C)$ is compared with the model's $r_i = [\hat{q}(A) - \hat{q}(B)] - [Q_1^{1/2}(A) - Q_1^{1/2}(B)]$ by

$$\beta_1 = \frac{\sum_i r_i d_i}{\sum_i d_i^2}, \qquad \kappa_1 = \frac{\beta_1 - \beta_1^{(8)}}{1 - \beta_1^{(8)}}, \tag{7}$$

and learned(m) requires $\beta_1 \geq 0.30$, its lower bound ≥ 0.15, $\kappa_1 \geq 0.20$ and a positive paired lower bound of $\beta_1 - \beta_1^{(8)}$. **Result.** NOT_LEARNED: both gate models (objective horizon $H = 3$) are defined FAILs (β_1 0.393 and 0.262, κ_1 -0.890 and -1.301), below the exact window-8 predictor's $\beta_1^{(8)} = 0.679$ (Figure 9); the remaining 12 models were not trained. Dev cross-entropy was flat at about 1.12 from step 1,000. **Licence.** "This recipe failed the registered learnability gate"—a scoped feasibility result that says nothing negative about representations.

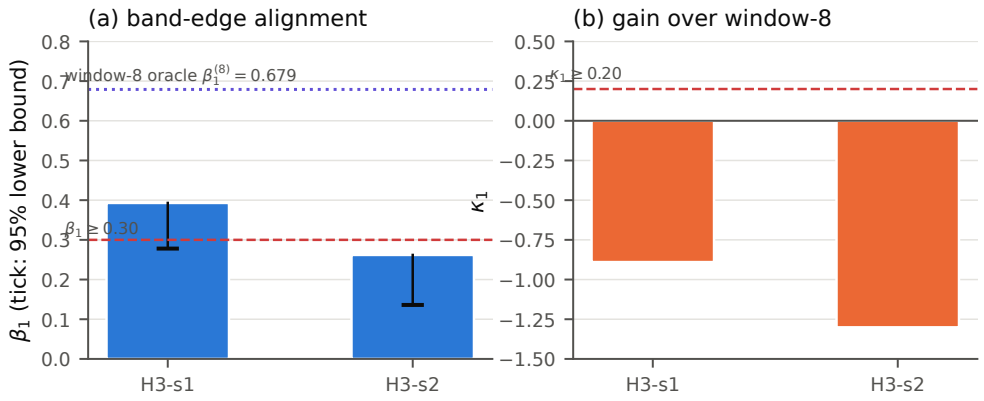


Figure 9: Orientability in trained models, learnability gate on validation: (a) band-edge alignment β_1 with its 95% lower bound against the threshold 0.30 and the exact window-8 value; (b) the normalised gain κ_1 against 0.20. Source: `agent-handoff/jobs/0033/review.md`.

9 Secondary programme: geometry and learning speed

Question. Does a metric-coupled "conductance" kernel (horizontal edge lengths $1+0.2\cos(2\pi y/11)$, conductances $1/l^2$) delay a grid-defined regret-threshold event by at least 250 steps relative to the flat kernel, in each of three paired models, on the same cylinder and emission? **Design.** 27-point step grid; PASS when mean regret $\leq 5\%$ of G_C at three consecutive grid points; paired bootstrap bounds (`docs/proposals/X5_G1_TRAINING_PROTOCOL_V4.md`). **Result.** Paired delays 250, 0 and 0 steps; one pair's upper bound is $0 < 250$, so the hypothesis is **REJECTED** on dev, with no censoring; the programme was closed without a fresh test. **Interpretation.** The kernel change is confounded with movement speed (the feasibility gate showed a large speed difference), so this is not a curvature null. A mean-rate-matched successor is a listed but unscheduled option.

10 Secondary programme: non-abelian transport and crossing order

10.1 Crossing order in the oracle: order-dependence certified

Construction. A 4×4 torus with the pilot's lazy walk (each move and stay with probability $1/5$). Each vertex emits its own token except an anchor $a_\star = (2, 2)$, which emits a cue revealing a hidden fibre value $x \in \{0, 1, 2\}$. Crossing the x-seam applies the transposition $a = (01)$ to the fibre, crossing the y-seam applies $b = (12)$; every face is flat except one corner face with a 3-cycle flux, and the fibre is redrawn at rate $\eta = 1/50$ (a 48-state lift). For a segment γ since the last cue, the holonomy is $\rho(\gamma) = g_{e_n} \circ \cdots \circ g_{e_1}$ and the Parikh vector $\kappa(\gamma) = (k_{x^+}, k_{x^-}, k_{y^+}, k_{y^-})$ counts directed seam crossings. Two abelian control processes, AB (a on both seams) and ZC (3-cycles), have the same counts but no order effect. **Outcome criteria.** (i) Designed: on designed witness families the cue-normalised TV between members of different holonomy is ≥ 0.3 while every commutative competitor is constant; (ii) natural: the natural excess log-loss of the best Parikh predictor $G_{\text{Parikh}}(32) \geq 10^{-3}$ nats and the fraction M_{32} of histories with row-KL ≥ 0.01 is $\geq 1/32$, both as certified enclosures. **What ran.** Two technical corrections (a key accumulation in one gate and a sign error in another gate's estimator), each confirmed by the next run. **Result.** GO, with the natural criterion met: witness TVs 0.851, 0.695, 0.524; exact zeros in AB, ZC and the controls; $G_{\text{Parikh}}(32) = 2.636 \times 10^{-3}$ nats (enclosure width $\sim 10^{-60}$) and $M_{32} = 0.0468$; no window of at most 7 symbols carries order information (exact). The ladder of commutative competitors is in Figure 10. **Licence.** Oracle facts about one designed process; a GO supports designing a

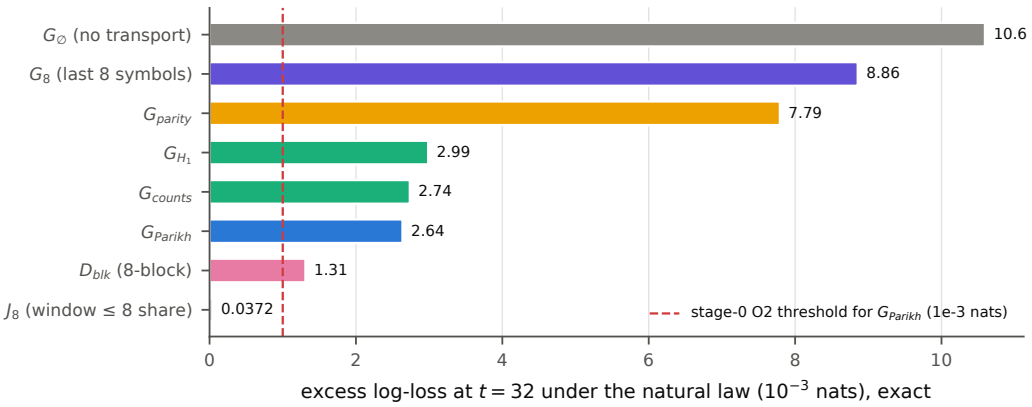


Figure 10: Crossing order in the oracle: exact natural excess log-loss at $t = 32$ of the Bayes predictor restricted to each commutative statistic (no transport; last 8 symbols; parity; H_1 class; unsigned counts; Parikh vector), the 8-block comparator D_{blk}, and the share J_8 of the gap carried by windows of at most 8 symbols; dashed line: the natural-criterion threshold. Every function of a statistic has at least that statistic's excess. Source: the certified stage-0 values quoted in `agent-handoff/planning/responses/X6S1-FROZEN-v1.md` §2.1, from `agent-handoff/jobs/0066/review.md` and `x6-stage0-oracle-store/run/report.json`.

trained stage, it does not authorise training. A descriptive note: the literal product-of-experts comparator has a transport-independent component (about 19 standard errors above zero), so it is not used as an order signal in the trained study.

10.2 Crossing order in trained models: do transformers use it?

Question. Do small causal transformers trained only by next-symbol prediction on natural histories of the non-abelian process (arm NA) make predictions that depend on the order of seam crossings, beyond the Parikh statistic and its coarsenings? The claim is behavioural; no mechanism is claimed.

Design (Figure 11). Arms NA, AB and ZC × seeds 1–4: 12 models, each trained for 30,000 updates on 2^{20} fresh histories with the pilot architecture and recipe; for each seed every arm starts from the same initial state and uses the same batch-index sequence. Training runs on the Colab free-tier GPU in resumable 1,000-update chunks (model, optimiser, scheduler and RNG state); every outcome-bearing evaluation runs locally on CPU in float64 from hashed weights. Training came in three waves: a smoke wave, a first wave (NA-s1, NA-s2, ZC-s1) and a second wave (the other nine, released only after the learnability gate said GO). The local stages prepared pools, registries, oracle and scoring checks and the training bundles; ingested each wave with integrity checks, the learnability gate and learning curves; and finally evaluated, decided and unsealed.

Primary estimand. Each eligible test history h (a cue present, age $n \geq 8$, end vertex next to the anchor) is paired with an exact uniform draw h' from its own Parikh class (same prefix, cue, age, end vertex and directed crossing counts). With $\Delta\hat{q} = \hat{p}_c(h) - \hat{p}_c(h')$ and $\Delta q^* = q^*_c(h) - q^*_c(h')$ on the cue-normalised laws,

$$\beta_{\mathrm{ord}}(m) = \frac{\sum_i \langle \Delta\hat{q}_i, \Delta q^*_i \rangle}{\sum_i \|\Delta q^*_i\|^2}. \tag{8}$$

Every function of the Parikh key scores exactly 0 (the pair shares the key), every function of the cue-free segment—including every function of the last 8 symbols—scores 0 in expectation, and the oracle scores 1. The control-adjusted slope is $\tilde{\beta}(s) = \beta_{\mathrm{ord}}(\text{NA-}s) - \max\{\beta_{\mathrm{ord}}(\mathrm{init}(s)), \overline{\beta}_{\mathrm{ord}}(\mathrm{AB}), \overline{\beta}_{\mathrm{ord}}(\mathrm{ZC})\}$, and **C-ORD** is supported iff $\mathrm{mean}_s \tilde{\beta}(s) \geq 0.25$, its 97.5% bootstrap lower bound exceeds 0.05, $\tilde{\beta}(s) > 0$ in at least 3 of 4 seeds, and a tail diagnostic passes.

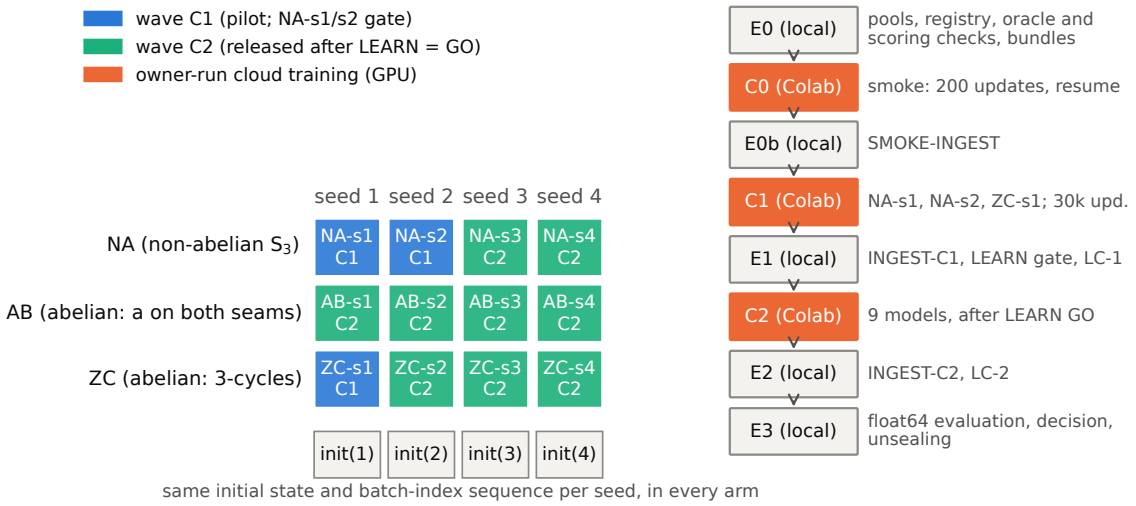


Figure 11: Crossing order in trained models, design: three arms × four seeds sharing four initial states, two training waves, and the alternation of local and cloud stages that I ran. The figure uses the protocol's stage labels (C0–C2 for the smoke, first and second training waves; E0–E3 for the local stages). Source: the frozen protocol §4.1–§4.4, §5, §8; wave parameters (smoke wave: 200 steps, $K = 100$; first and second waves: 30,000 steps, $K = 1{,}000$) from `x6-stage1-store/stages/E0/frozen_C*.json` (bundle id, steps and K only), via `docs/research_summary/data/x6s1_status.json`.

Log-loss claims and the empirical-Bernstein bound. For the quantised, ε-smoothed readout ($Q = 2^{20}$, $\varepsilon = 10^{-6}$) the per-row excess loss $X_i = \mathrm{KL}(q^*(H_i) \,\|\, p^Q(H_i))$ lies in $[0, B]$ with $B = 17$. With $n = 2m = 2^{21}$ rows, $\bar{X} = \frac{1}{n}\sum X_i$, $Z_k = (X_{2k-1} - X_{2k})^2/2$, $\bar{Z} = \frac{1}{m}\sum Z_k$, $L = \ln(2/\delta)$, $a = B\sqrt{L/m}$, $b = B^2 L/(12m)$ and $\sigma_{\mathrm{up}} = (a + \sqrt{a^2 + 4(\bar{Z} + b)})/2$, the protocol proves

$$P\Big(\mu \le \bar{X} + \sigma_{\mathrm{up}}\sqrt{2L/n} + \frac{BL}{3n}\Big) \ge 1 - \delta \tag{9}$$

from a one-sided Bernstein moment bound and a paired U-statistic for the variance, and computes the bound outward in exact and directed-rounding arithmetic. **SHARP**(s) holds iff the bound at $\delta = 0.025/4$ is below the stage-0 lower endpoint of $G_{\mathrm{Parikh}}(32)$: then model NA-s is not a function of the Parikh statistic or any coarser one. A secondary TARGET requires recovering 25% of that gap. Designed criteria use the bag- and bigram-matched AB-versus-BA family (3,090 pairs).

Learnability gate. Before any order statistic exists, an NA pilot model must have natural excess log-loss credibly below the exact window-8 gap $G_8(32) = 8.855 \times 10^{-3}$ nats on fresh validation rows (bootstrap upper bound at 97.5%). Passing means "better than every function of the last 8 symbols"; it does not mean order use. GO iff NA-s1 or NA-s2 passes. Only statuses and the decision are released; the statistics are sealed.

What ran (Figure 13).

- *Implementation*: an API contract and two independent test authors, eleven modules within line limits set by coordinator addenda (footprint only; no scientific change), and a coordinator full suite of 4,288 passed at the code freeze.
- *Authorisation*: I authorised the frozen protocol by its SHA-256 hash, a local budget of about 43 CPU-h (forecast range 23–70), and cloud use of about 1–4 GPU-h.
- *Preparation, attempt 1*: stopped at its first lineage check; nothing scientific ran. Two defects: a constant path one level short of its value, and a lineage check that refused the authorisation record written by the same run. Both were corrected.

- *Preparation, attempt 2*: all ten gates passed, from authorisation through pools, registries, oracle and scoring checks to the cloud bundles, and the bundles were built.
- *Smoke wave*: I ran it in Colab. The first ingest was INVALID at the provenance check, because a hash pasted with a line break produced a notebook cell that did not compile but was still recorded, and the check treated every recorded source as executed. The fix skips sources that do not compile, which cannot have executed anything; the second ingest on the same snapshot passed. One recorded open defect is that no bundle re-issue mechanism exists for a retrain; it is not needed unless a retrain occurs.
- *First wave*: the three models passed all four integrity checks, and the learnability gate **passed with the released decision GO** (both NA pilot models passed).
- *Second wave*: I ran it; the nine models passed all four integrity checks, so all 12 models were admitted.
- *Evaluation and decision*: the first evaluation attempt was INVALID because every model chunk exceeded the 3 GiB per-process memory limit (a full-pool vectorised forward peaked at about 3.0 GiB against a forecast of 1.2 GB). The correction evaluates in row blocks of 2^{16} with byte-identical outputs (peak 1.11 GiB) and was re-frozen; the regenerated initialisation chunk was bit-identical. All 16 predictor chunks then completed, and the decision stage passed every step and unsealed.

Total local compute was 79.55 CPU-h, about 21 CPU-h of it in the failed attempt (Figure 14b); I extended the budget beyond the approved 23–70 CPU-h. Cloud training took one Colab session per wave, about 10 s (smoke), 24 min (first wave) and 69 min (second wave) by the session records.

10.2.1 Results at the decision stage

All numbers in this subsection are from the decision-stage report written after unsealing (`x6-stage1-store/stages/E3z/report.json`, sha256 `90be2081...`) and the coordinator's review of it. Figure 12 summarises them.

Outcome. INCONCLUSIVE under the protocol's ninth decision rule, with the licence "descriptive only". The registered qualifiers record that one control limited the designed comparison in seed 1, that both control arms learned in all four seeds, that the finest commutative statistic the NA models beat is parity, that one designed criterion is unresolved, and that a length profile is reported. Every validity gate passed, all 12 models were admitted and learned (the learnability gate said GO, and all twelve passed the test-time learnability check), the natural placebos were clean, the tail diagnostic passed and precision was adequate in every seed.

Natural order use. On the informative natural partner pairs at $t = 32$ (the oracle has $\beta_{\mathrm{ord}} = 1$, the Parikh-class predictor 0), the four NA models reach $\beta_{\mathrm{ord}} = 0.047,\ 0.090,\ 0.072,\ 0.049$, the AB controls 0.001–0.004, the ZC controls 0.001–0.008 and the initialisations about 0. The per-seed contrasts are $C_s = 0.044,\ 0.088,\ 0.064,\ 0.045$, each with a 95% interval far from zero, and the mean is $\tilde{\beta} = 0.061$ with $\mathrm{LB}_{0.975} = 0.0595$. The registered C-ORD claim requires a mean of at least 0.25, so C-ORD is *not supported*; every seed falls in the registered "low" band ($\tilde{\beta}(s) < 0.10$) and none in the "order" band.

Designed order use. On the designed witness family W2 the NA models' regret is $R_{W2} \approx$ 0.080–0.087, above the bar $(3/4)\Delta^{\mathrm{lo}}_{W2} \approx 0.0458$, so the designed order criterion fails in seeds 2–4. Seed 1 is unresolved because the commutative control ZC-s1 responded to the designed W2 contrast (placebo $\beta_{W2} = 0.209$; other controls ≤ 0.006 in magnitude). Descriptively, the ZC controls reach a W2 regret similar to the NA models' (0.077–0.094) while the AB controls stay near 0.20, so the designed regret does not separate order-sensitive from commutative models. SHARP and TARGET were certified for no NA model, and the finest commutative ladder rung the NA models beat is parity.

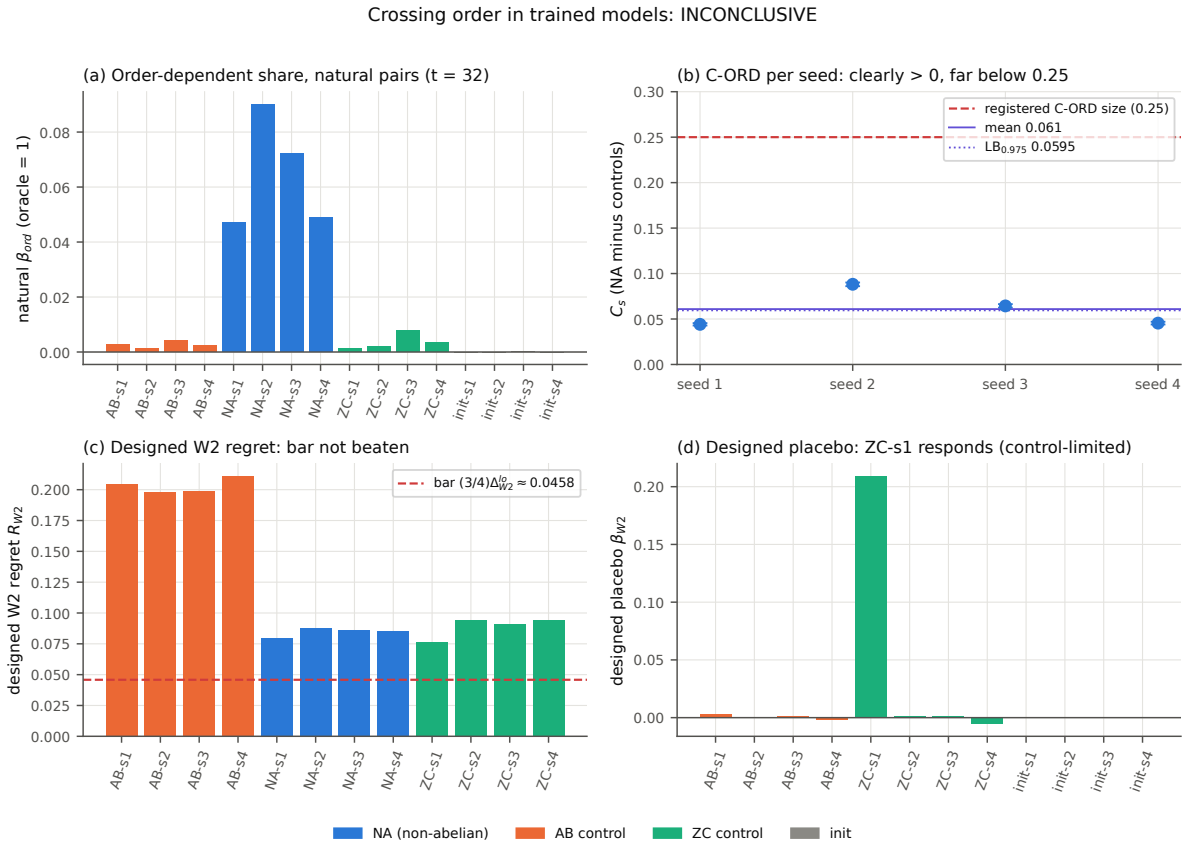


Figure 12: Crossing order in trained models, decision stage. (a) Natural β_{ord} per predictor on the informative $t = 32$ partner pairs. (b) Per-seed C-ORD contrast C_s with 95% intervals, the mean and $\text{LB}_{0.975}$, against the registered effect size 0.25. (c) Designed W2 regret against the bar $(3/4)\Delta^{\text{lo}}_{W2}$. (d) Designed placebo β_{W2} of the controls (ZC-s1 fails). Source: `x6-stage1-store/stages/E3z/report.json` via the snapshot `docs/research_summary/data/x6s1_result.json`.

Why INCONCLUSIVE. The "order not detected" rule needs the designed criterion resolved in all four seeds. Every other condition of that rule holds; the single designed placebo failure of ZC-s1 leaves seed 1 unresolved, and the rules are applied as registered, without reclassification.

Reading. Within the licence: next-token training on natural non-abelian transport histories produced a weak but reproducible sensitivity to the order of seam crossings, present in every seed and absent from the commutative controls, at about one sixteenth of the oracle's order information. It falls far short of the order use the study was designed to detect, and the designed probes do not show it. Whether more training, larger models or a different curriculum would close the gap is a new question.

10.3 Why does a commutative control respond to the designed placebo?

Question. The trained crossing-order study was INCONCLUSIVE only because one commutative control (seed 1, trained on the commutative $\mathbb{Z}_3$ version of the process) responded to the designed W2 contrast (placebo 0.209). The stored values showed two other controls responding to the designed W1 contrast (-0.133 and -0.218). Why do they respond, and can the designed-placebo machinery be reused? **Design.** No training. An exact computation shows that on these designed families the non-abelian oracle's answer for one ordering equals the commutative answer, and for the other ordering equals the commutative answer with one crossing missed. Any order-dependent miscount by a commutatively trained model therefore shows up along the order contrast, although an exactly commutative predictor gives zero. The registered test reverses the direction of one or

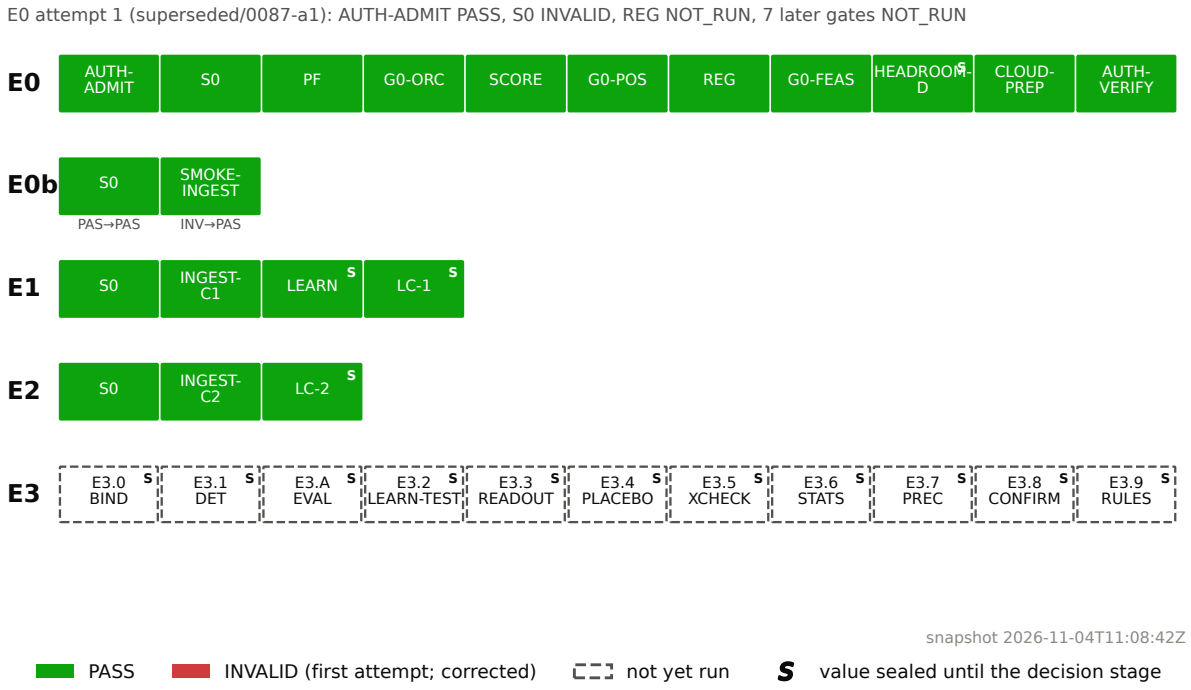


Figure 13: Crossing order in trained models, gate pipeline with statuses, under the protocol's gate names. Filled: PASS; outlined dashed: not yet run; "S": the gate's values are sealed until the decision stage; arrows below a box give the status history over attempts. Statuses and gate names only. Source: `x6-stage1-store/GATES.jsonl` and `superseded/0087-a1/GATES.jsonl` (fields gate, status, utc only; the values field is never read), via the snapshot `docs/research_summary/data/x6s1_status.json`; stage order from `X6S1-FROZEN-v1.md` §8.

both loops on never-used histories. The order contrast stays the same in every variant (ratio 1), while every sign-symmetric miscount reverses sign when both loops are reversed (ratio −1). The 16 stored designed results were first reproduced bit for bit. **What ran.** Three stages on 26–27 October, all gates passed, 3.9 CPU-hours in all. **Result** (`x6zc-store/report.json`; 1,024 fresh histories). The seed-1 control's W2 response replicated (0.207, interval 0.205–0.209). Relative to it, the response is 0.06 with both loops reversed, and 0.18 and 0.83 with one loop reversed. It is not invariant, as order use would be, and it does not reverse, as a symmetric miscount would. The registered outcome is UNEXPLAINED (not invariant to loop reversal). The two W1 controls' responses also replicated and reversed sign when both loops were reversed, so they are not order use in the oracle's direction. They fit an order-dependent miscount or an order-free effect of token identity, which W1 cannot separate. Fresh controls were stable, and removing matched or coincident pairs changed no outcome. **Consequences.** The designed-placebo comparison may be reused as a behavioural contrast only with explicit empirical controls; it must not be described as automatically excluding every predictor trained on a commutative process. The crossing-order verdict stays INCONCLUSIVE.

11 Engineering and process

11.1 Coordinator, workers and the mailbox

I organised execution around a separate git repository, `agent-handoff`, holding the protocol (`PROTOCOL.md`), one directory per job (`task.md`, `status.json`, `report.md`, `review.md`), the request and control files, planning requests and responses, owner decisions (immutable files plus numbered

addenda) and the coordinator's state (newest entry first). Codex acted as coordinator until 14 October, followed by a chain of Claude coordinator sessions, each handing over to a fresh one when its context grew too long. Each takeover wrote an assumption record, because release verifiers bind the issuer's identity; one takeover race was resolved by having the late session stand down. Workers were headless sessions or subagents launched per job, with context caps that forced rotation to fresh sessions; a transfer record registers each new worker identity. More than 100 jobs had been created by 26 October. Two operational hazards recurred: a shared subscription hitting usage limits (handled by waiting, never by switching accounts), and permission classifiers blocking some actions (never bypassed). I approved and installed an automatic-resume scheduler.

11.2 The cloud training pipeline and its integrity gates

The trained crossing-order study was the first trained on a GPU. The coordinator builds deterministic bundles (code archive, data, initial states, a ticket with seeds, steps and checkpoint interval, expected batch and RNG digests for every chunk) and releases a bundle hash to me, and I run a fixed notebook in the browser; only one cell (the bundle hash) may be edited. Every chunk records its batch digest and PCG64 state digest; the export carries a manifest whose hash I relay. Locally, four checks run per model before any evaluation: a weights check (manifest, inventory and canonical weights digests), a provenance check (every session and execution record matches the permitted cell templates, commit, protocol and bundle), a data-identity check (data, initial state, per-chunk batch and RNG digests), and a completeness check (a linked chain of exactly one record per checkpoint). An admission lock then fixes the model's only admissible chain. GPU training is not claimed to be reproducible; data, batch sequence, initial state and every evaluation are.

11.3 Defects found and corrected

The correction route was exercised many times, always before any outcome-bearing quantity existed or with documented independence from it. Examples: a 2π phase edge in the first four-symbol origin attempt; a module split under the 400-line rule in the orientability oracle study; an integer/string key mismatch and the ridge tolerance (discussed above) in counterfactual forcing; a `Fraction(dict)` call, a byte-order mark and a lazy sequence, test fixtures inside the project root and a missing reader in the four-symbol origin test; a key accumulation and an estimator sign error in the crossing-order oracle study; a constant path, a lineage check and a non-compiling pasted notebook cell in the trained crossing-order study; and, in the readout-attribution study, a lineage check that refused the stage's own entry records. Two classes of defect were caught only by real runs: those where tests exercised synthetic inputs but not the real output of a reused function (the `Fraction(dict)` case), and those that depend on the live environment (the pasted cell). Both led to added checks.

12 Compute

Figure 14 summarises local compute from the store ledgers. Including every metered run (preflight test suites among them), the follow-up studies used about 115.3 CPU-hours in the ledgers shown, 79.6 of them in the trained crossing-order study's local ingest and evaluation (its training ran on a cloud GPU); the 17 pilot trainings took 4.4 wall-clock hours on a six-core laptop CPU (13–21 minutes each). The largest items are the two training studies (learning speed, six models; orientability, two models), the exact dynamic programme of the crossing-order oracle study, and the trained crossing-order study. The full test in the selected world used 2.87 CPU-hours in its store ledger; its study ledger, which also counts every test-suite and dry-run repeat before the re-freezes, holds 5.16 CPU-hours (`agent-handoff/HWSC_CPU_LEDGER.json`). The stages I approved

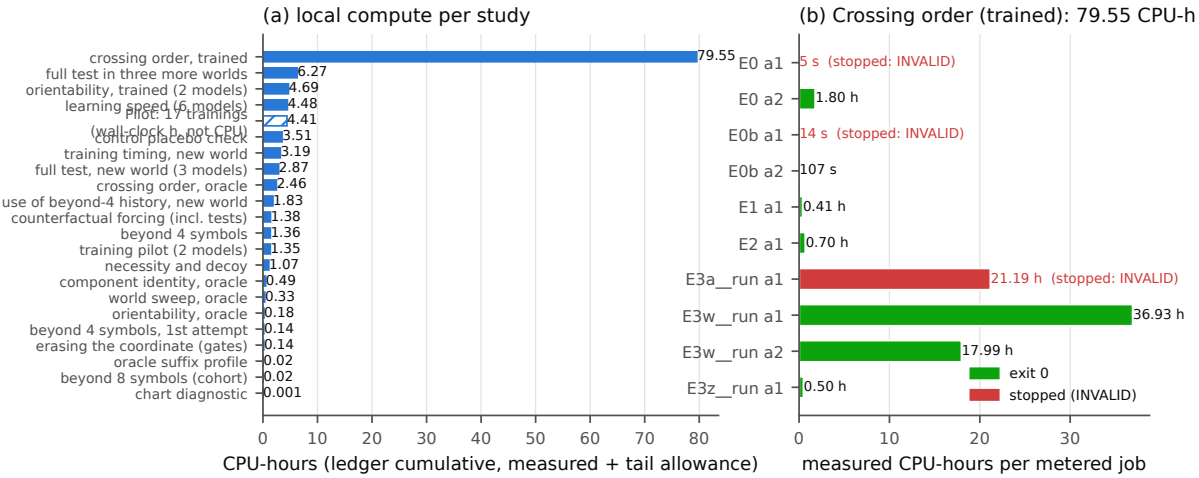


Figure 14: (a) Cumulative CPU-hours per study from each store's `cpu_ledger.json` (measured plus tail allowance; includes metered test suites); the hatched bar is the summed wall-clock time of the 17 pilot trainings, which predate the meter. (b) Trained crossing-order study, measured CPU per metered job and attempt, under the protocol's stage labels (E0 preparation; E0b smoke ingest; E1 and E2 ingest of the two training waves; E3a, E3w and E3z evaluation and decision; a1, a2 attempts). Sources: `<store>/cpu_ledger.json` for the stores named in `make_figures.py` (`LEDGERS`), snapshotted in `docs/research_summary/data/compute_ledgers.json`; `x6-stage1-store/cpu_ledger.json` (accounting fields only) via `data/x6s1_status.json`; `artifacts/MetricRecords/*/extra.json` (`wall_time_s`).

used about 3.0 CPU-hours against a forecast of 3.2; the repeated test rounds after the code corrections were not in that forecast. The two follow-ups on its models used 3.19 (training timing) and 1.83 (use test) CPU-hours in their store ledgers, and 7.08 and 4.73 in their study ledgers (`agent-handoff/HWSD_CPU_LEDGER.json`, `agent-handoff/HWSU_CPU_LEDGER.json`); I released their CPU pause lines on 2 November and asked for actual CPU to be reported instead of forecasts. The worlds study used 6.27 CPU-hours in its store ledger and 15.6 in its study ledger, which also counts its nine trainings (`agent-handoff/HWSG_CPU_LEDGER.json`).

13 Current status and next steps

- **Origin beyond four symbols in the selected world** is decided: SUPPORT in all three new models (§6.7). The training pilot (27–28 October) passed; the full test ran on 29–30 October after my approval. Its code is merged into the main branch.
- **Timing of the beyond-four signal in training** is complete (§6.8), and **use of that history by the predictions** is decided: RESPONDS in all three models, share not assessed (§7.5). Both codes are merged into the main branch.
- **The full test in three more worlds** is complete (§6.9): SUPPORT in all three models of two worlds, the third inconclusive, no claim for all worlds. Its code is merged into the main branch.
- **Next, approved for planning on 4 November.** (1) What part of the belief the circle code keeps: whether its length, and not only its angle, tracks how certain the belief is, tested on the existing models against the exact oracle. (2) A small diagnostic of whether a model can learn the non-orientable world at all, before any new orientability test. A follow-up measuring, with a larger sample, how much of the predictions' response runs through the circle code is planned but paused until (1) reports. Real runs go one at a time.
- **The three parallel studies without training** are complete: the world sweep selected a

world (§6.6); the control's placebo response remains unexplained (§10.3); the circle code is dominant and the method passes the decoy test (§7.4). Together they used 9.5 of the 12 CPU-hours set aside for them.

- **Readout attribution of the circle code** is decided: USED in all three models, with the layer-2 and oracle-phase codes also USED (§7).
- **Crossing order in trained models** is decided: INCONCLUSIVE (§10.2.1). A natural follow-up is the gap between the observed order sensitivity ($\tilde{\beta} \approx 0.06$) and the registered size (0.25) under longer training or larger models.
- **Other options** recorded by the coordinator and by me include an independent replication of the pilot's O models, a speed-matched successor of the learning-speed study, a comparison across architectures and training objectives, a follow-up on the four-symbol margin and comparator scale, and the remaining tasks of a seven-task project reorganisation. None is authorised.
- **Records out of date.** `state/PROGRESS.md` and the README's "Current follow-up status" date from 17 October and still describe the four-symbol origin test as running; it completed with EXCLUSION, the crossing-order oracle study completed with GO, and the trained crossing-order study has since been decided. This document reflects the coordinator's reviews, which are the more recent records.

14 Threats to validity and limitations

1. **One scoped causal claim.** The pilot evidence is representational, and the first two intervention designs stopped at gates. The one causal-use result concerns a single registered linear code, at one position and site, for one kind of counterfactual (an x-history rotation with the last symbol kept); it excludes neither other encodings nor other carriers. Its necessity follow-up is tied to it by an exact identity, and its decoy test covers only constructed decoys. In the selected world, the use test shows that the predictions respond to history beyond four symbols, but how much of that runs through the circle code was not assessed; the training-timing study makes no use claim and no causal claim about training.
2. **One toy setting.** One small architecture and recipe, synthetic HMMs on tiny lattices, a few seeds (three in the pilot, at most four per arm); the worlds study varies only the world's parameters within one family. Nothing is claimed about natural language or large models, other architectures, or populations of seeds.
3. **Statistics.** Pilot decisions use sign consistency and a data-derived envelope, not significance tests; panels are partitions within runs. Most later bounds are nominal bootstrap bounds; only the log-loss claims of the trained crossing-order study carry a finite-sample guarantee.
4. **Measurement choices.** Vietoris–Rips over $\mathbb{F}_2$, $M = 512$, the longest bar as S; four one-factor sensitivity variants. Circular coordinates use one cocycle and can give disconnected points arbitrary offsets.
5. **Exposure.** The circular audit, the counterfactual-forcing study, the four-symbol origin test, the readout-attribution study and its necessity and decoy follow-up reuse the three pilot models, whose test panels had been unblinded; they draw fresh histories protected by registries, but the models are not fresh. Likewise, the training-timing study and the use test reuse the full test's three models after its result was known.
6. **Margins and controls.** The four-symbol margin sits above the oracle's own value in the pilot world (the full test therefore moved to a world where it does not); the untrained-chart control of the full test was unavailable for two of its three models (and for five of six in

the worlds study); the P control is one-sided; the learning-speed kernel is confounded with speed.

7. **Reproducibility scope.** One machine and environment; one of 17 pilot trainings was retrained; the clean-rerun gate formally failed; GPU training in the crossing-order study is not reproducible by design.

8. **Process.** One post-data tolerance change (in the counterfactual-forcing study) occurred without my prior approval and I ratified it afterwards. Records written by agents were reviewed by other agents; I approved decision points but did not audit every computation.

15 Conclusion

Under controlled conditions, next-token training on a hidden walk produces a learned circle that reflects the world's topology, aligns with Bayesian belief geometry, and exceeds what the last symbol permits. Where it comes from is only partly known: the last-symbol embedding carries much of it, beliefs converge after a few symbols, and the beyond-four-symbol covariance of the learned phase is below a margin that even the oracle's phase does not reach in the pilot world. In a nearby world with more such information, three new models carry it: their learned phase depends on history beyond the last four symbols, at about 90% of the oracle's level. The model does use it: at the final readout, the registered circle code carries about 85% of the model's response to a change in the x-history, in all three models; it is the main carrier but not the only one, and on decoys whose readout ignores the code the same method says "not used". The follow-up programme mostly produced well-defined stops rather than findings, and the stops taught something about one-sided controls, nonlinear encodings, non-specific interventions, fragile chart rules and margins set without oracle checks. The trained crossing-order study was designed to avoid each of these failure modes on a process where order provably matters. It reached its decision with every validity gate passed and found weak but reproducible natural order sensitivity in every seed, far below the registered effect size, so its preregistered verdict is INCONCLUSIVE and not a claim of order use. The readout-attribution study answered the use question with an exact, linear attribution at the model's readout, after the two earlier intervention designs had failed for reasons of method. For the origin question, an oracle sweep found a nearby world whose beyond-four signal is 4.7 times the registered margin; a pilot and a full test there, under the unchanged margin and decision rule, returned SUPPORT in all three new models. The origin question therefore has its first positive answer: with enough history information in the world, the learned circle reflects beliefs accumulated beyond the last few symbols, not only the latest observations. In those models the signal was present no later than the first validated chart, before the predictions beat every last-four-symbol predictor, and the predictions themselves respond to history beyond the last four symbols, in the direction of the belief, at about 90% of the oracle's discrimination. Whether that response runs through the circle code in this world remains open. Repeated unchanged in three more worlds, the origin result held in all three new models of both worlds that reached the endpoint, each capturing at least half of the oracle's signal; the third world gave no answer, so generality across worlds is supported but not established.

A Glossary

Term	Meaning
O, P, N, U	Emission conditions: smooth Gaussian; axis-permuted; uniform; one symbol per state
$b^{(32)}$, $b^{(1)}$	Exact belief after 32 symbols; posterior from the last symbol alone
F_1, F_2	Exact next-symbol law; joint law of the next two symbols
G_C, regret, captured	Context gain; mean KL from the oracle to the model; $1 - \text{regret}/G_C$
S, $D_{r,i}$, u_r	Normalised longest finite H_1 bar; double contrast; noise envelope
Δ_{geom}	Spearman alignment with $b^{(32)}$ minus alignment with $b^{(1)}$
F1, H2, H3, H3′, H4	The pilot's preregistered rule and hypotheses: hole in the cylinder only; geometry follows the full belief; F1 under P; belief alignment under P; the hole appears after history use
Baselines	Initialisation; last-symbol embedding; previous-token mixing; context average
m_K, B_K, r_4	Circular posterior mean from the last K symbols; $\mathbb{E}\|m_{32} - m_K\|$; $m_{32} - m_4$
Δ_4	Four-symbol origin estimand $\mathbb{E}[u \cdot r_4]$ for the learned chart phase u
ψ	Readout-attribution share: the part of the model's oracle-aligned response carried by the circle-code interchange
NA, AB, ZC	Crossing-order arms: the non-abelian process and its two commutative controls
Chart	Circular coordinate built from an H_1 cocycle on landmarks (LCC rule: largest component $\geq 95\%$)
Holonomy, local system	Composition of fibre permutations along a path; an assignment of permutations to edges, flat on a face if their product around it is the identity
Parikh vector	Counts of each directed seam crossing, ignoring order
$G_S(32)$	Excess log-loss at $t = 32$ of the best predictor that sees only statistic S
β_{ord}, C-ORD	Within-Parikh-class order slope; the primary order claim of the trained crossing-order study
SHARP, TARGET	Its log-loss claims: below $G_{\text{Parikh}}(32)$, and below 75% of it
Gate	A check that must pass before a stage's products are interpreted
Registry	Set of digests of every previously exposed history, used to certify fresh pools
Sealed	Written with a hash and released only at the decision stage or a stop
Technical correction	Coordinator-ruled fix of a documented defect; at most two jobs per defect
Release	Coordinator-signed permission for a specific stage of a study

B All stages, gates and outcomes

This table is the lookup key into the project records. It uses the internal study labels of Table 2, the protocols' own stage and gate names, and the numbers of the decision-log entries (D-. . .) and coordinator jobs whose reviews record each outcome.

Stage / study	Date	Decisive gate(s)	Outcome	Record
E0 (S1)	10-13	G-A	PASS	D-017; reports/E0
E1 (S2)	10-13	G-B, G-C, G-D	PASS; P one-sided	README (E1)
E2 (S3–S4)	10-13	G-E, G-F; F1 rule; H2	F1 SUPPORTED; H2 consistent	reports/E2
E3 (S5–S6)	10-13	F1 rule under P; H3′; H4	H3 rejected (uninf.); H3′ SUPPORTED; H4 REJECTED	reports/E3
E4 (S7–S8)	10-13	G-G; G-H	G-G PASS; G-H FAIL	D-049; reports/E4
X4 Phase B	10-13	coverage	INCONCLUSIVE	D-052
X4 Phase B2	10-14	witnesses	scoped NO-GO	D-054, D-055
Circular audit	10-14	descriptive	BEYOND_ SYMBOL_AND_ MIXING	D-057
X4-F	10-14	G3, G4	INCONCLUSIVE / FAMILY_ UNMATCHED	D-063
K8 cohort	10-14	oracle headroom	FAIL	x4-history-feas-store
X5 G1	10-14	H5 rule (dev)	REJECTED; closed (D-081)	job 0013; D-073
Oracle profile	10-14	exploratory	accepted, qualified	job 0014; D-074
K4	10-15	chart_calibration	INCONCLUSIVE	job 0018; D-078
C1	10-15	K4 chart dependency	blocked by freeze	job 0018 review
D-1	10-15	PF, S0, G0–G6	PASS	job 0020; D-080
Chart diagnostic	10-15	giant fraction ≥ 0.95	GO	job 0023
X2a stage 0	10-15	P3, P4, A3	GO_P1_ NONADDITIVE	job 0025; D-084
D-2a	10-15	learnability (stage 1)	NOT_LEARNED	job 0033
C1′ S3	10-16	G0, H1–H5, N0	PASS (after R11)	jobs 0039, 0041
C1′ S4	10-16	M1, M2-cal	INCONCLUSIVE / FAMILY_ UNMATCHED	jobs 0042, 0044
K4b E1	10-17	G0 … P1 (10 gates)	PASS (after R25, R26, R28)	jobs 0049–0055
K4b E2	10-17	H2-FRESH, T-PRE, ENDPOINT	EXCLUSION (3/3 models)	job 0057
X6 stage 0	10-18	PF, S0, G0–G7, D	GO_X6_NATURAL (after X7, X8)	jobs 0063–0066
X6S1 IMPL	10-20	gate 0	complete (freeze H)	job 0086
X6S1 E0	10-20	AUTH-ADMIT … CLOUD-PREP, AUTH-VERIFY	attempt 1 INVALID (S0); attempt 2 all PASS	jobs 0087, 0089
X6S1 E0b	10-20	SMOKE-INGEST	attempt 1 INVALID; attempt 2 PASS	jobs 0090, 0092
X6S1 E1	10-20	INGEST-C1, LEARN, LC-1	PASS; LEARN = GO	job 0093
X6S1 E2	10-20	INGEST-C2, LC-2	PASS; 12 models admitted	job 0094
X6S1 E3	—	E3.0–E3.9	all PASS; INCONCLUSIVE (rule 9)	0095–0099
C2 IMPL	10-22	gate 0; freeze	complete (FREEZE 24ff24cc)	jobs 0100–0106

Stage / study	Date	Decisive gate(s)	Outcome	Record
C2 S1	10-22, 10-26	release check; G0 (vii); H1–H5	attempt 1 refused; attempts 2, 3 FAIL_ TECHNICAL (each corrected); attempt 4 all PASS	jobs 0107–0111
C2 S2–S4	10-26	M0, C0c, F1; C0v, L1, R1, N2, SURVIVAL; X1, V3, Y1, Y2, P1	all PASS; N_test 4096	jobs 0112–0114
C2 S5	10-26	T-PRE, RESP-SPEC, NUM, ENDPOINT	R USED; M UPSTREAM_USED; S* X_PHASE_USED (3/3 models)	job 0115
HWS S0	10-26	G0; known cases	attempt 1 FAIL_ TECHNICAL (scope); attempt 2 KC9 FAIL (owner decision); attempt 3 PASS	jobs 0127, 0130, 0135
HWS S1–S3	10-26	STAGE_S1, STAGE_S2, STAGE_S3	HWS_ SELECTED/T0	job 0136
X6ZC A–C	10-26, 10-27	known cases; bit-exact reproduction; loop-sign variants	P: UNEXPLAINED/ NOT_NA_ INVARIANT; W1 cells: ZC_NOT_ COMMUTATIVE/ NOT_NA_ DIRECTION	jobs 0149, 0153, 0155
C2ND S1–S5	10-27	REG2, T-PRE, RESP-SPEC, NUM	N-R CODE_ DOMINANT; D DECOY_NOT_ USED; N-M CODE_ DOMINANT_M (3/3 models)	jobs 0163–0167
HWS stage B KB	10-27	G0, KB0–KB6	attempts 1, 2 stopped by code defects (each corrected); attempt 3 all PASS (KB2 bitwise)	jobs 0168, 0170, 0172
HWS stage B TRAIN, EVAL	10-28	B1, B4, B5, B6, B8a, B9a	HWSB_PASS	jobs 0173–0175
HWS stage C IMPL	10-29	tests; synthetic dry run; freeze	complete (re-frozen after each correction)	jobs 0176–0180, 0183, 0185, 0190, 0194
HWS stage C KC	10-29	G0C, KC0–KC9	attempts 1, 2 stopped by code defects (each corrected); attempt 3 all PASS (KC2 bitwise)	jobs 0181, 0184, 0186
HWS stage C TRAIN	10-29	TRAIN (3 models)	PASS	jobs 0187–0189
HWS stage C E1	10-29	G0C, H1C, REG1, H2, L1, C0, CERT, P1	all PASS; $N = 3072$	job 0191

Stage / study	Date	Decisive gate(s)	Outcome	Record
HWS stage C E2	10-30	REG2, H2-FRESH, T-PRE, ENDPOINT	REG2 attempt 1 stopped by the output cap (corrected); SUPPORT (3/3 models)	jobs 0192, 0195, 0196
HWS track D	11-02	FREEZE, AUTH, SCHED, BINDING_AUDIT, ACCEPT_SCORE, BOOTSTRAP, STATEMENTS	all PASS; HWSD_ REPORT (D1, D5, D6 TRUE; D2, D3, D4 FALSE)	job 0222
HWS track U OF	11-02	OF-B, OF-0 … OF-5	attempt 1 stopped at the CPU pause line (corrected); attempt 2 OF_PASS_ RESPONSE_ONLY	jobs 0200, 0206
HWS track U KC	11-03	G0U, KC0–KC6	attempts 1–3 stopped by configuration and procedure defects (each corrected); attempt 4 all PASS	jobs 0229, 0231, 0233, 0234
HWS track U E1, REG2, E2	11-03	G0U, H1-U, REG1, S3, H2-U, H3-U, H5-U, BASIS, M0, X1, KC-U, P1; REG2; RELEASE-B, S7, H2-FRESH-U, T-PRE, NUM, ENDPOINT	all PASS; RESPONDS (3/3 models); share INCONCLUSIVE/ ORACLE_ FEASIBILITY	jobs 0235–0237
HWSG KC, O	11-03, 11-04	known cases; O (world selection, oracle gates per world)	KC attempts 1, 2 stopped by code and data defects (each corrected); attempt 3 all PASS; O PASS (3 worlds)	jobs 0238–0245
HWSG TRAIN, REG1	11-04	TRAIN (3 models per world); REG1	PASS	jobs 0246–0249
HWSG E1	11-04	G0C, H1G, REG1_LOAD, H2, L1, ORACLE-VAL, B4-VAL, C0-CAL, C0-VAL, CERT-VAL, P1	lo, mid all PASS (mid attempt 1 stopped by a certificate defect, corrected); hi INCONCLUSIVE/ CHART_ UNAVAILABLE at C0-VAL	jobs 0250, 0251, 0254, 0255
HWSG REG2, E2, CROSS	11-04	REG2; RELEASE-B, H2-FRESH, T-PRE, ENDPOINT, RATIO; CROSS	REG2 attempt 1 stopped (procedural); E2 attempt 1 stopped at T-PRE (code defect); lo SUPPORT, mid SUPPORT (3/3 models each); GENERAL_ UNAVAILABLE; capture at least half	jobs 0256–0264

C Sources

- Pilot: `README.md`; `docs/RESEARCH_SUMMARY.md`; `docs/RESEARCH_PLAN_EN.md`; `PREREGISTRATION.md`; `PREREGISTRATION_X4.md`; `reports/E0` to `reports/E4`; `state/DECISIONS.md`.
- Follow-ups: `docs/proposals/`; the frozen protocols in `agent-handoff/planning/responses/`; the job reviews and reports in `agent-handoff/jobs/`.
- Coordination: `agent-handoff/COORDINATOR_STATE.md`; `agent-handoff/MORNING_REPORT_20261015_EN.md`; `agent-handoff/NEXT_RESEARCH_AND_WORKFLOW_EN.md`.
- Figure data and their provenance: `docs/research_summary/make_figures.py` and `docs/research_summary/data/`.

Paths starting with `agent-handoff/` or naming a `*-store` directory are execution records kept next to the repository, not in it. The review of each job is `agent-handoff/jobs/<job>/review.md`, with the job numbers of Appendix B.

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